

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Centre State and Inter State Relations - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Four dimensions of Centre-State relations



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Polity 13 - Centre-State and Inter-State Relations - Complete Topic Package

Subject: Indian Polity | **Topic:** 13 | **GS-II + Prelims** | **Content control:** 2026-08-28 **Approval:** false - awaiting explicit user approval. **Evidence key:** [FACT] constitutional, judicial, statutory or source-verified proposition; [ANALYSIS] reasoned exam synthesis; [CURRENT] dated status; [LIMIT] qualification preventing overstatement.

Package method, scope boundary and current control

- Source order followed: certified Core owner Polity/basic/Centre-State-Relations.md -> optional Advanced owner Polity/advanced/13_Centre-State-and-Inter-State-Relations.md -> official local PYQ papers and keys -> Constitution, judgments and official current controls -> Qdrant not used.
- [LIMIT] Foundation and Core are independently answer-complete. Optional Advanced adds representation, economic-federalism and scholar depth only.
- [CURRENT] Status is controlled to **16 August 2026, Asia/Kolkata**.
- [CURRENT] Standard Seventh Schedule examination counts are **Union 100, State 61, Concurrent 52**. Historical numbering retains omitted and inserted entries.
- [CURRENT] The 2019 Inter-State River Water Disputes Amendment Bill passed Lok Sabha but has **not become law**; the existing ad-hoc tribunal architecture remains controlling.
- [CURRENT] The Sixteenth Finance Commission award for 2026-31 retains **41% vertical devolution** and adds a **10% contribution-to-GDP** criterion.
- [CURRENT] The November 2025 Article 143 opinion controls Governor assent: no fixed judicial deadlines and no deemed assent, while prolonged unexplained inaction can be reviewed through a direction to act.
- [LIMIT] Federal theory is owned by Polity 12; detailed Emergency doctrine by Polity 14; Governor office by Polity 19; Finance Commission institution by Polity 29. This package remains complete on how those mechanisms affect relations.
- Package target: **11 routed PYQs, 28 original MCQs, 8 remedials, 7 original solved Mains questions, 15 guided Mains answers and 14 original visuals**.

Roadmap

Stage	Coverage	Exam outcome
Framework	Four dimensions and constitutional map	Organises every answer
Legislative	Articles 245-255, Lists, overlap and State-field entry	Solves competence questions
State-law control	Prior sanction, reservation and assent	Handles Governor/President traps
Doctrines	Harmonious construction, supremacy, repugnancy, pith and substance	Answers 2019 GS-II
Administrative	Articles 256-263, directions, delegation, Article 365	Explains central leverage
Services/agencies	AIS, integrated institutions and CBI consent	Connects administration to conflict
Emergency-linked relations	Articles 355-365, especially 355-357, 360 and 365	Separates duty, remedy and fiscal direction
Financial	Articles 265-293, tax sharing, grants and borrowing	Builds fiscal architecture
Evolution	Planning Commission to FC-GST-NITI model	Answers 2025 GS-II
16th FC	Accepted devolution, formula and grant shifts	Current fiscal control
Inter-State	Water disputes, ISC, Zonal Councils and full faith	Solves institutional questions
Common market	Articles 301-307 and Jindal Stainless	Completes economic federalism
Commissions	Rajamannar, Sarkaria and Punchhi	Supplies reform menu
Practice	Eight PYQs, 36 MCQs and seven Mains models	Converts knowledge into marks

Scope ownership and cross-links

- **Polity 12:** meaning, classifications, federal/centralising features and federalism as Basic Structure.
- **Polity 14:** National, State and Financial Emergencies in full.
- **Polity 19:** Governor appointment, government formation, discretion and office-specific doctrine.
- **Polity 29:** Finance Commission constitution, detailed recommendations and State-wise devolution.
- **Polity 33:** GST Council composition, voting and tax mechanics.
- **Polity 35:** Inter-State Council and Zonal Councils may recur as dedicated bodies, but their relation function is complete here.

DEEP-REVIEW LEARNING CONTRACT

Control	Binding rule for this package
Syllabus boundary	Complete Polity Basic/Core is answer-complete before optional Advanced depth.
Text hierarchy	Constitution/Act/rule/notification -> binding judgment -> authoritative institution -> Constituent Assembly material -> standard textbook.
Legal precision	State exact Article, Part, Schedule, amendment, case, date, institution, procedure, exception and current operative status.
Doctrine method	Text -> institutional mechanism -> controlling case -> exception/limit -> present legal status.
Chronology	Enactment, commencement, amendment, judgment and implementation dates remain separate.
Boundary method	Topic ownership and cross-owner bridges are explicit; adjacent PYQs never become fabricated direct routes.
Practice contract	Every solved item has demand decoding, examiner-grade model, timed compression plan, marks rationale and answer-specific improvement.
Approval	This immutable successor remains approved: false pending explicit approval.

Canonical Basic/Core owner: upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Polity\basic\Centre-State-Relations.md

Canonical topic owner: upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Polity\basic\Centre-State-Relations.md **Optional**

Advanced owner:

upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Polity\advanced\13_Centre-State-and-Inter-State-Relations.md

Official syllabus mapping: upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Polity\OFFICIAL-UPSC-SYLLABUS-MAPPING.md

EVIDENCE, PYQ AND CURRENT-STATUS CONTROL

- **Four independent ledgers:** literal syllabus/index, indispensable

prerequisites, standard textbook taxonomy and complete routed 2018-2026 PYQ demands were built before repair.

- **Hostile search:** missing Articles, Parts, Schedules, amendments, cases,

institutional mechanisms, exceptions, chronology, source status and cross-owner boundaries are hard failures.

- **Answer rule:** claim -> exact constitutional/statutory/case evidence ->

institutional analysis -> exception or qualification.

- **Current-status note, rechecked 2026-09-05:** Rechecked 2026-09-05: Special Reference No. 1 of 2025 rejects rigid assent timelines and deemed assent while preserving limited mandamus for prolonged, unexplained, indefinite inaction. The Sixteenth Finance Commission retains 41 percent vertical devolution; Article 263, statutory Zonal Councils, the 1956 river-disputes framework and DSPE consent remain legally distinct coordination routes.

Authoritative live sources:

- <https://legislative.gov.in/documents/constitution-of-india>
- https://api.sci.gov.in/supremecourt/2025/39157/39157_2025_1_1501_66169_Judgement_20-Nov-2025.pdf
- <https://interstatecouncil.gov.in/>
- <https://www.mha.gov.in/en/page/zonal-council>
- <https://www.indiacode.nic.in/handle/123456789/1664>
- <https://fincomindia.nic.in/asset/doc/commission-reports/16th-FC/16fc-EM.pdf>
- <https://gstcouncil.gov.in/>

BASIC LEARNING SESSION



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

SESSION 1 - CONSTITUTIONAL MAP: FOUR DIMENSIONS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Centre-State relations operate through distinct legislative, administrative, financial and inter-State channels.

Technical definition: Articles 245-263 and 268-293 allocate competence, implementation, coordination and fiscal capacity.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A high-scoring answer identifies the dimension before diagnosing conflict.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- legislative relations
- administrative relations
- financial relations
- inter-State relations
- constitutional allocation
- federal coordination

How to use them: Frame the answer through legislative relations; define administrative relations, connect financial relations with inter-State relations to explain the mechanism, and use constitutional allocation for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Four dimensions of Centre-State relations



Centre-State relations operate through legislative, administrative, financial and inter-State channels.

Dimension	Principal Articles	Core question
Legislative	245-255, Part XI	Who may make the law and what happens on conflict?
Administrative	256-263, Part XI	Who implements, directs, delegates and coordinates?
Financial	265-293, Part XII	Who taxes, receives, grants and borrows?
Inter-State/economic	261-263 and 301-307	How are disputes, recognition and the common market managed?

- [ANALYSIS] The dimensions interact. A legally State subject may depend on Union finance; a shared tax may require administrative coordination; a water dispute may become a political and fiscal conflict.
- [ANALYSIS] High-scoring answers therefore identify the dimension before listing grievances.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CONSTITUTIONAL MAP: FOUR DIMENSIONS

START / CONCEPT: Constitutional map: four dimensions
 |
 v
 EXACT TERMS: legislative relations · administrative relations · financial relations · inter-State relations · constitutional allocation · federal coordination
 |
 v
 MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Identify the field, constitutional route, institutional check and remedy.
 |
 v
 CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The same policy dispute can combine legal competence, implementation and finance.
 |
 v
 UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not reduce federal relations to the Seventh Schedule alone.
 |
 v
 ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: A high-scoring answer identifies the dimension before diagnosing conflict.

SESSION 2 - LEGISLATIVE RELATIONS: COMPETENCE BEFORE CONFLICT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Legislative relations determine territorial reach and which legislature may act on a subject.

Technical definition: Articles 245-248 and the Seventh Schedule must be applied before conflict doctrines or Article 254.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Competence comes before supremacy in every legislative-relations answer.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 245
- Article 246
- Seventh Schedule
- territorial nexus
- Article 248
- legislative competence

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 245; define Article 246, connect Seventh Schedule with territorial nexus to explain the mechanism, and use Article 248 for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Legislative competence decision path



A competence dispute should be solved by identifying substance, locating the entry and reconciling before applying supremacy.

Territorial reach: Article 245

- [FACT] Parliament may legislate for the whole or any part of India; a parliamentary law is not invalid merely because it has extra-territorial operation.
- [FACT] A State legislature ordinarily legislates for the State or part of it.
- [FACT] The territorial-nexus doctrine permits State law to affect an extra-State object where the connection is real and the liability is pertinent to that connection.

Distribution: Article 246 and the Seventh Schedule

List	Standard current count	Primary legislature	Illustrations
Union	100	Parliament	Defence, currency, inter-State trade, inter-State migration/quarantine
State	61	State legislature	Police, public health, agriculture, markets, prisons
Concurrent	52	Both	Criminal law, marriage, education, forests

- [FACT] Article 246(1) gives Union List competence notwithstanding the other clauses.
- [FACT] Article 246(2) creates concurrent competence; Article 246(3) gives State List competence subject to clauses (1) and (2).
- [FACT] Article 248 and Union Entry 97 place residuary legislative and taxing power with Parliament.
- [FACT] The 42nd Amendment moved education, forests, weights and measures, protection of wild animals and birds, and administration of justice from State to Concurrent.
- [LIMIT] List entries are fields of legislation, not narrow statutory definitions; courts interpret them broadly.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - LEGISLATIVE RELATIONS: COMPETENCE BEFORE CONFLICT

START / CONCEPT: Legislative relations: competence before conflict
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Article 245 · Article 246 · Seventh Schedule · territorial nexus · Article 248 · legislative competence
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Classify the law by true nature, locate the entry and then test overlap.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Valid incidental overlap can survive while residuary matters belong to Parliament.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not invoke Article 254 for a conflict outside the Concurrent field.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Competence comes before supremacy in every legislative-relations answer.

SESSION 3 - PARLIAMENT IN THE STATE FIELD

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The Constitution permits Parliament to enter the State field through five separately triggered routes.

Technical definition: Articles 249, 250, 252, 253 and 356 differ in initiation, duration, territorial scope and amendment control.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The State List is primary, but its constitutional doors are not interchangeable.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 249
- Article 250
- Article 252
- Article 253
- Article 356

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 249; define Article 250, connect Article 252 with Article 253 to explain the mechanism, and use Article 356 for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Parliament in the State field



Five routes permit Parliament to legislate on State subjects for different triggers and durations.

Article	Trigger	Duration/effect	Federal safeguard
249	Rajya Sabha: two-thirds present and voting; national interest	Resolution up to one year, renewable; law has six-month tail	State chamber supplies trigger
250	National Emergency in operation	Law has six-month tail after Emergency ends	Temporary crisis route
252	Resolutions by two or more State legislatures	Applies to requesting/adopting States; Parliament alone amends/repeals	State-initiated consent
253	Treaty or international decision implementation	Operates as needed for implementation	National external obligation
356	Parliament exercises State legislative power during President's Rule	Parliamentary law continues until altered by competent legislature	Bommai review and restoration safeguards

Mnemonic: R-N-S-I-P - Rajya Sabha, National Emergency, States' request, International obligation, President's Rule.

- [LIMIT] Article 249 does not require an Emergency.
- [LIMIT] Under Article 252 a participating State cannot unilaterally amend the parliamentary enactment.
- [LIMIT] Farm-market or disaster examples must be analysed through the actual List entry and statute, not political labels alone.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PARLIAMENT IN THE STATE FIELD

START / CONCEPT: Parliament in the State field

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Article 249 • Article 250 • Article 252 • Article 253 • Article 356

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Match national interest, emergency, State request, treaty or breakdown to its exact provision.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: National coordination is possible without permanently transferring the State List.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Article 249 does not require an Emergency and Article 252 begins with State resolutions.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The State List is primary, but its constitutional doors are not interchangeable.

SESSION 4 - UNION CONTROL OVER STATE LEGISLATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Union control may arise through prior presidential sanction, gubernatorial reservation or presidential consideration.

Technical definition: Articles 200, 201 and 304(b) create distinct procedural controls over State Bills.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Prior sanction and reservation occur at different stages and produce different consequences.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 200
- Article 201
- Article 304(b)

- prior sanction
- reservation
- Governor assent

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 200; define Article 201, connect Article 304(b) with prior sanction to explain the mechanism, and use reservation for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Union control over State legislation



Union control can arise before introduction, through reservation, or through presidential consideration.

Prior presidential sanction

- [FACT] Some State Bills require previous presidential sanction, including a Bill imposing a reasonable restriction under Article 304(b).
- [FACT] A State Bill affecting High Court powers so as to endanger its constitutional position must be reserved under the proviso to Article 200.
- [ANALYSIS] Prior sanction and reservation are distinct: one is permission before legislative introduction or consideration; the other sends a passed Bill for presidential decision.

Articles 200 and 201

- [FACT] A Governor presented with a State Bill acts through the constitutional options of assent, withholding, return of a non-Money Bill, or reservation for the President as applicable.
- [FACT] Under Article 201 the President may assent or withhold assent; for a non-Money Bill the President may direct return through the Governor for reconsideration.
- [FACT] If the State legislature passes the returned Bill again, Article 201 does not impose the Article 200-style obligation that assent must follow.

Current Governor-assent control

- [CURRENT] The 20 November 2025 advisory opinion rejects judicially fixed timelines and deemed assent.
- [CURRENT] Prolonged, unexplained and indefinite inaction remains open to limited review; a court may require action without choosing the constitutional option.
- [LIMIT] Do not reproduce the superseded April 2025 timelines as current law.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - UNION CONTROL OVER STATE LEGISLATION

START / CONCEPT: Union control over State legislation

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Article 200 · Article 201 · Article 304(b) · prior sanction · reservation · Governor assent

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Identify when permission is needed, who reserves the Bill and which options remain with the President.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: State legislation may face Union review without every reserved Bill becoming invalid.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not carry forward superseded fixed assent timelines or deemed assent as current law.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Prior sanction and reservation occur at different stages and produce different consequences.

SESSION 5 - FEDERAL SUPREMACY AND HARMONIOUS CONSTRUCTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Courts preserve both legislative fields where possible and use supremacy only for irreconcilable conflict.

Technical definition: Pith and substance, harmonious construction and Article 254 form a sequential competence-and-conflict inquiry.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Harmonious construction is the preservation rule; federal supremacy is the tie-breaker.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- pith and substance
- harmonious construction
- Article 254
- repugnancy
- M. Karunanidhi
- federal supremacy

How to use them: Frame the answer through pith and substance; define harmonious construction, connect Article 254 with repugnancy to explain the mechanism, and use M. Karunanidhi for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Doctrines that manage legislative overlap



Overlap doctrines protect both jurisdictions before Union predominance resolves an irreconcilable conflict.

Doctrine	Test	Consequence
Pith and substance	What is the law's true nature and dominant character?	Incidental encroachment does not invalidate competence
Harmonious construction	Can both entries/laws receive meaningful operation?	Reconciliation is preferred
Federal supremacy	Does an irreconcilable constitutional priority remain?	Union predominance operates as tie-breaker
Repugnancy	Are Union and State laws on a Concurrent matter directly inconsistent?	Article 254 ordinarily gives Union law priority
Colourable legislation	Is competence being evaded by form?	Indirect transgression is invalid
Territorial nexus	Is there a real connection to the State?	Supports extra-territorial effect of State law

Article 254

- [FACT] A State law repugnant to parliamentary law on a Concurrent subject is void to the extent of repugnancy.
- [FACT] A reserved State law receiving Presidential assent may prevail in that State.
- [FACT] Parliament may later add to, amend, vary or repeal that State law.
- [LIMIT] Article 254 is not the first step in every List dispute. First identify competence and attempt harmonious construction.

2019 PYQ thesis: Harmonious construction is the ordinary preservation rule; federal supremacy is the exceptional last-resort rule. Sarkaria called supremacy a technique to avoid absurdity and resolve conflict.

Eighth-edition doctrine sequence: do not start with repugnancy

1. Identify the law's true nature (pith and substance)
2. Locate the competent legislative entry
3. Test whether any overlap is merely incidental/ancillary
4. Reconcile entries and provisions through harmonious construction
5. If two laws occupy a Concurrent field, test Article 254 repugnancy
6. Apply constitutional Union priority only to the irreconcilable residue

[FACT] **Territorial nexus** addresses the reach of a State law under Article 245, while **pith and substance** addresses its subject classification. **Colourable legislation** tests disguised lack of competence, not political motive.

[ANALYSIS] This sequence protects both levels of government before invoking Union predominance. It turns federal supremacy from a slogan into a constitutionally bounded conflict rule.

[LIMIT] Presidential assent under Article 254(2) cannot cure a State law enacted outside State competence, and Parliament may later override an assented State law.

Answer-writing evidence chain

- **Claim:** Indian legislative federalism prefers reconciliation before supremacy.
- **Named evidence:** Articles 245-246 allocate reach and fields; Article 254 resolves Concurrent repugnancy; *M. Karunanidhi* supplies the conflict inquiry.
- **Analysis:** Pith and substance and harmonious construction preserve workable regulatory overlap, while Article 254 prevents contradictory commands in the Concurrent field.
- **Qualification:** Federal supremacy is constitutionally authorised but should be used only after competence and reconciliation analysis, not as a presumption that every Union law displaces State law.

Cross-link: basic/Constitutional-Interpretation-Doctrines.md is the consolidated doctrine map; this package owns their Centre-State application.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FEDERAL SUPREMACY AND HARMONIOUS CONSTRUCTION

START / CONCEPT: Federal supremacy and harmonious construction
|
v
EXACT TERMS: pith and substance · harmonious construction · Article 254 · repugnancy · M. Karunanidhi · federal supremacy
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Find true nature, reconcile entries and test direct Concurrent-field conflict.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: This approach protects autonomy while preventing contradictory legal commands.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Presidential assent cannot cure legislation outside State competence.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Harmonious construction is the preservation rule; federal supremacy is the tie-breaker.

SESSION 6 - ADMINISTRATIVE RELATIONS: IMPLEMENTATION, DIRECTIONS AND CONSEQUENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Administrative relations connect State implementation duties with bounded Union directions.

Technical definition: Articles 256-257 permit compliance and specified directions, while Article 365 supplies only a possible inference.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

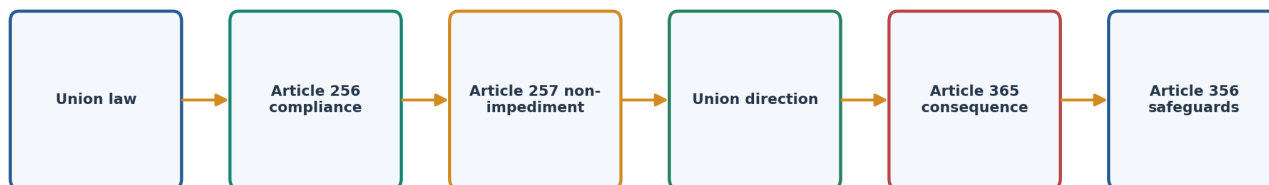
A direction is not the same as an automatic Article 356 proclamation.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 256
- Article 257
- Union directions
- Article 365
- railway protection
- constitutional compliance

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 256; define Article 257, connect Union directions with Article 365 to explain the mechanism, and use railway protection for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Administrative relation chain



Union directions move from implementation duties to a possible Article 365 consequence, but President's Rule remains separately controlled.

Articles 256 and 257

- [FACT] State executive power must ensure compliance with parliamentary laws and existing laws applying in the State.
- [FACT] Union executive power extends to giving necessary directions for that purpose.
- [FACT] State executive power must not impede Union executive power.
- [FACT] The Union may direct construction/maintenance of communications of national or military importance and measures for railway protection, with constitutionally governed extra costs.

Other direction fields

- [FACT] Article 339(2) permits Union directions concerning schemes essential for Scheduled Tribe welfare.
- [FACT] Article 350A concerns facilities for mother-tongue instruction at the primary stage for linguistic-minority children.

Article 365 is not automatic President's Rule

- [FACT] Failure to comply with Union directions permits the President to hold that a situation has arisen in which State government cannot be carried on according to the Constitution.
- [LIMIT] Article 365 creates a constitutionally relevant inference, not an automatic mechanical proclamation.
- [FACT] Any Article 356 action remains subject to parliamentary approval, temporal rules and *S.R. Bommai* judicial review.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ADMINISTRATIVE RELATIONS: IMPLEMENTATION, DIRECTIONS AND CONSEQUENCE

START / CONCEPT: Administrative relations: implementation, directions and consequence
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Article 256 · Article 257 · Union directions · Article 365 · railway protection · constitutional compliance
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Trace duty, direction, alleged non-compliance and the separate emergency safeguard.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The Union can secure implementation without converting States into field offices.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Article 365 is evidentiary, not self-executing President's Rule.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: A direction is not the same as an automatic Article 356 proclamation.

SESSION 7 - DELEGATION, SERVICES AND AGENCIES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Cooperative administration uses reciprocal entrustment, shared services and consent-based investigation.

Technical definition: Articles 258, 258A and 312 coexist with DSPE Act State-consent requirements and constitutional-court exceptions.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Delegation, services and agencies work only when Union-State control and accountability remain genuinely joint.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 258
- Article 258A
- Article 312
- All-India Services
- CBI consent
- DSPE Act

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 258; define Article 258A, connect Article 312 with All-India Services to explain the mechanism, and use CBI consent for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Shared administration and investigative friction



Shared administration combines delegation, common services, integrated institutions and consent-based central investigation.

Mutual delegation

- [FACT] Article 258 permits the President, with State consent, to entrust Union executive functions to a State or its officers.
- [FACT] Parliamentary law may confer powers and impose duties on States even without consent, with adjustment for administrative costs.
- [FACT] Article 258A permits a Governor, with Union consent, to entrust State executive functions to the Union or its officers.

All-India Services: Article 312

- [FACT] IAS, IPS and Indian Forest Service are All-India Services.
- [FACT] Rajya Sabha must pass the prescribed national-interest resolution before Parliament creates a new All-India Service.
- [ANALYSIS] Shared cadres combine national standards and State implementation, but disciplinary control and cadre allocation can generate federal friction.

- [LIMIT] Indian Forest Service is not the Indian Foreign Service.

CBI consent

- [FACT] Section 6 of the Delhi Special Police Establishment Act requires State consent for DSPE/CBI powers within a State.
- [FACT] Withdrawal of general consent ordinarily makes case-specific consent necessary for fresh investigations.
- [FACT] Supreme Court and High Courts may order a CBI investigation through constitutional jurisdiction without State consent.
- [CURRENT] The 2024 *State of West Bengal v. Union of India* decision upheld maintainability of the State's Article 131 suit against preliminary objection; it did not finally decide all merits.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - DELEGATION, SERVICES AND AGENCIES

START / CONCEPT: Delegation, services and agencies

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Article 258 · Article 258A · Article 312 · All-India Services · CBI consent · DSPE Act

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Separate consensual delegation, statutory duties, common cadres and investigative jurisdiction.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: National standards and cross-border investigation coexist with State executive autonomy.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Indian Forest Service is an All-India Service; Indian Foreign Service is not.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Delegation, services and agencies work only when Union-State control and accountability remain genuinely joint.

SESSION 8 - EMERGENCY-LINKED CENTRE-STATE CONSEQUENCES: ARTICLES 355-365

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Articles 355-365 contain distinct duties, emergency consequences, immunities and special provisions.

Technical definition: The relation sequence is Union duty under 355, exceptional remedy under 356, temporary legislative consequence under 357 and possible non-compliance inference under 365.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Emergency-linked Centre-State consequences under Articles 355-365 separate Union duty, exceptional remedy and fiscal emergency.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 355
- Article 356
- Article 357
- Article 360
- Article 365
- S.R. Bommai

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 355; define Article 356, connect Article 357 with Article 360 to explain the mechanism, and use Article 365 for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Provision	Centre-State consequence	Exam-safe limit
Article 355	Union duty to protect every State against external aggression and internal disturbance and ensure constitutional government	A duty and constitutional context; not a self-executing takeover power
Article 356	Presidential proclamation where State government cannot be carried on according to the Constitution	Parliamentary approval, time limits and <i>S.R. Bommai</i> review apply
Article 357	Parliament may confer State legislative power on the President and authorise delegation during President's Rule	Does not permanently transfer the State List
Articles 358-359	Modify specified Fundamental-Rights operation/enforcement during a National Emergency	Primarily a rights effect, not a fresh allocation of legislative fields
Article 360	Permits financial-emergency directions, including State financial propriety and reservation of specified State Money Bills	Never proclaimed as of the control date; do not treat it as ordinary borrowing control
Articles 361-364	Immunities and limited transitional/special provisions	Not general Union direction powers
Article 365	Non-compliance with Union directions may support a conclusion relevant to Article 356	It is an evidentiary bridge, not automatic President's Rule

[ANALYSIS] The constitutional sequence is **duty (355) -> exceptional remedy (356) -> temporary legislative consequence (357)**. Article 365 may supply relevant material, but neither it nor Article 355 bypasses the safeguards governing Article 356. Article 360 is a separate fiscal-emergency route and must not be confused with ordinary Article 293 borrowing consent.

Major judicial controls across the relations map

Decision	Controlled proposition
<i>State of West Bengal v. Union of India</i> (1962)	States are not sovereign entities immune from constitutionally valid Union power
<i>State of Rajasthan v. Union of India</i> (1977)	Article 356 satisfaction is not wholly beyond review, though the earlier review standard was deferential
<i>M. Karunanidhi v. Union of India</i> (1979)	Repugnancy requires a real, direct and irreconcilable conflict in the Concurrent field
<i>S.R. Bommai v. Union of India</i> (1994)	Federalism is Basic Structure; Article 356 is reviewable and majority ordinarily belongs on the floor
<i>Jindal Stainless v. State of Haryana</i> (2016)	Part XIII does not promise tax-free trade; discriminatory State taxation is the central Article 304(a) concern
<i>Union of India v. Mohit Minerals</i> (2022)	GST Council recommendations are recommendatory and preserve legislative autonomy
<i>State of West Bengal v. Union of India</i> (2024)	The State's Article 131 CBI-consent suit survived the preliminary objection; merits were not finally decided

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - EMERGENCY-LINKED CENTRE-STATE CONSEQUENCES: ARTICLES 355-365

START / CONCEPT: Emergency-linked Centre-State consequences: Articles 355-365
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Article 355 · Article 356 · Article 357 · Article 360 · Article 365 · S.R. Bommai
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Test material, proclamation, parliamentary control, judicial review and temporary consequences separately.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Constitutional breakdown can alter ordinary relations while safeguards preserve federal status.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: article 360 is separate from ordinary Article 293 borrowing consent.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Emergency-linked Centre-State consequences under Articles 355-365 separate Union duty, exceptional remedy and fiscal emergency.

SESSION 9 - FINANCIAL RELATIONS: CONSTITUTIONAL ARCHITECTURE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Fiscal relations allocate taxing authority, revenue, grants, immunities and borrowing constraints.

Technical definition: Articles 265, 268-280 and 292-293 create a system of assignment, distribution, grants and consent.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The constitutional architecture of financial relations gives State autonomy practical meaning through usable revenue.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 265
- Article 270
- Article 271
- Article 275
- Article 280
- Article 293

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 265; define Article 270, connect Article 271 with Article 275 to explain the mechanism, and use Article 280 for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Financial-relations article map



Tax authority, revenue assignment, grants, the Finance Commission and borrowing create fiscal interdependence.

Foundational rules

- [FACT] Article 265: no tax shall be levied or collected except by authority of law.
- [FACT] The Concurrent List has no general tax entry; GST shared competence arises specially from Article 246A.
- [FACT] Article 276 permits taxes on professions, trades, callings and employments subject to the constitutional annual cap of Rs 2,500 per person.

Revenue-distribution map

Article	Mechanism	Exam distinction
268	Union levies; States collect and appropriate specified stamp duties	Not part of ordinary divisible-pool devolution
269	Union levies/collects and assigns specified inter-State taxes to States	Distinguish from IGST
269A	Union levies/collects inter-State GST and apportions it	GST Council framework
270	Union taxes distributed between Union and States	Divisible pool and FC shares
271	Parliament may impose Union-purpose surcharge	Surcharge proceeds are not shared
275	Grants-in-aid under constitutional criteria	Rules-based/statutory grants
282	Union or State grants for any public purpose	Discretionary policy leverage
280	Finance Commission	Periodic devolution and grants

Tax immunities and borrowing

- [FACT] Article 285 generally exempts Union property from State taxation, subject to parliamentary provision and transitional rules.
- [FACT] Article 289 generally exempts State property and income from Union taxation, subject to business/trade exceptions Parliament may regulate.
- [FACT] Article 292 governs Union borrowing; Article 293 limits State borrowing to within India.
- [FACT] A State requires Union consent to raise a loan where a Union loan or guaranteed loan remains outstanding, and consent may carry conditions.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FINANCIAL RELATIONS: CONSTITUTIONAL ARCHITECTURE

START / CONCEPT: Financial relations: constitutional architecture

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Article 265 · Article 270 · Article 271 · Article 275 · Article 280 · Article 293

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Distinguish assigned taxes, divisible-pool distribution, surcharges, grants and borrowing.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The Union and States remain fiscally interdependent despite separate tax fields.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: GST competence comes from Article 246A, not a general Concurrent List tax entry.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The constitutional architecture of financial relations gives State autonomy practical meaning through usable revenue.

SESSION 10 - EVOLUTION OF FISCAL FEDERALISM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Fiscal federalism moved from parallel plan and Finance Commission channels toward a Finance Commission-GST-NITI architecture.

Technical definition: The post-2015 system is more rules-based but retains cesses, conditional schemes and borrowing leverage.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

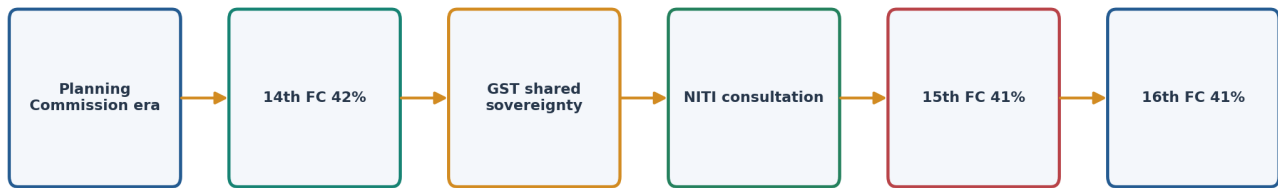
The evolution of fiscal federalism cannot be measured by a devolution percentage alone.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Planning Commission
- NITI Aayog
- Finance Commission
- divisible pool
- cesses and surcharges
- vertical imbalance

How to use them: Frame the answer through Planning Commission; define NITI Aayog, connect Finance Commission with divisible pool to explain the mechanism, and use cesses and surcharges for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Fiscal federalism evolution



Fiscal relations moved from plan-era discretion toward Finance Commission, GST and NITI-based interdependence.

Planned-development era

- Planning Commission and National Development Council shaped plan assistance outside the Finance Commission's constitutional cycle.
- Article 282 grants enabled national development priorities but increased executive discretion.
- States negotiated plan size and scheme assistance through a centralised planning structure.

Post-2015 architecture

- [FACT] NITI Aayog replaced the Planning Commission through executive resolution in 2015; it has no tax-devolution power.
- [FACT] The 14th Finance Commission raised vertical devolution to 42%, increasing untied tax share while scheme restructuring changed the wider transfer picture.
- [FACT] GST pooled major indirect-tax autonomy through Articles 246A, 269A and 279A.
- [FACT] The 15th and 16th Finance Commissions use 41%, accounting for the changed status of Jammu and Kashmir in the divisible-pool calculation.

Assessment

- [ANALYSIS] The system became more rules-based through Finance Commission devolution and a constitutional GST forum.
- [ANALYSIS] Re-centralisation persists through cesses/surcharges outside the divisible pool, centrally sponsored scheme conditions, borrowing consent and unequal administrative capacity.
- [LIMIT] "More devolution" cannot be assessed from the percentage alone; the divisible-pool base, grants and expenditure mandates matter.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - EVOLUTION OF FISCAL FEDERALISM

START / CONCEPT: Evolution of fiscal federalism

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Planning Commission · NITI Aayog · Finance Commission · divisible pool · cesses and surcharges · vertical imbalance

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Compare plan-era discretion, post-2015 institutions and the total transfer design.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Rules-based sharing increased while non-shareable levies and conditions can re-centralise finance.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Distinguish the divisible-pool share from gross Union tax revenue.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The evolution of fiscal federalism cannot be measured by a devolution percentage alone.

SESSION 11 - SIXTEENTH FINANCE COMMISSION: ACCEPTED 2026-31 CONTROL

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The Sixteenth Finance Commission governs constitutional tax devolution and major grants for 2026-31.

Technical definition: Its accepted framework retains 41 percent vertical devolution and balances equalisation, demography, ecology, area and GDP contribution.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Sixteenth Finance Commission formula for 2026-31 distributes a fixed vertical share through explicit horizontal trade-offs.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Sixteenth Finance Commission
- 41 percent
- income distance
- demographic performance
- forest and ecology
- contribution to GDP

How to use them: Frame the answer through Sixteenth Finance Commission; define 41 percent, connect income distance with demographic performance to explain the mechanism, and use forest and ecology for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Sixteenth Finance Commission horizontal formula



The horizontal formula combines equalisation, population, demographic, ecological and output considerations.

Criterion	Weight
Income distance	42.5%
Population (2011)	17.5%
Demographic performance	10%
Area	10%
Forest and ecology	10%
Contribution to GDP	10%

- [CURRENT] Vertical devolution remains **41% of the divisible pool** for 2026-31.
- [CURRENT] Contribution to GDP is a new 10% criterion; tax effort was removed.
- [CURRENT] Revenue-deficit, sector-specific and State-specific grants were discontinued in the accepted framework; local-body and disaster grants remain major grant channels.
- [CURRENT] Disaster-fund sharing is 90:10 for specified north-eastern/Himalayan States and 75:25 for other States.
- [ANALYSIS] The formula balances equalisation and contribution, but every criterion creates distributional winners and losers; legitimacy depends on transparent methodology.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SIXTEENTH FINANCE COMMISSION: ACCEPTED 2026-31 CONTROL

START / CONCEPT: Sixteenth Finance Commission: accepted 2026-31 control

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Sixteenth Finance Commission • 41 percent • income distance • demographic performance
• forest and ecology • contribution to GDP

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Separate vertical share from the horizontal distribution formula and grant channels.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Predictability improves, but formula choices redistribute bargaining gains among States.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not describe contribution to GDP as ten percent of national GDP; it is a formula weight.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The Sixteenth Finance Commission formula for 2026-31 distributes a fixed vertical share through explicit horizontal trade-offs.

SESSION 12 - GST COUNCIL AND FISCAL NEGOTIATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The GST Council is a joint constitutional forum for negotiated indirect-tax coordination.

Technical definition: Article 279A combines weighted voting with recommendatory decisions and separate legislative authority under Article 246A.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

GST turns tax autonomy into structured bargaining rather than extinguishing federal choice.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 279A
- Article 246A
- weighted voting
- consensus
- Mohit Minerals
- recommendatory

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 279A; define Article 246A, connect weighted voting with consensus to explain the mechanism, and use Mohit Minerals for the decisive comparison or qualification.

- [FACT] Article 279A creates a joint Union-State forum on GST rates, exemptions, thresholds, model laws and special rates.
- [FACT] The Union's vote has one-third weight and States together two-thirds; a decision requires at least three-fourths weighted votes of members present and voting.
- [FACT] *Union of India v. Mohit Minerals* (2022) held Council recommendations recommendatory, not binding law.
- [ANALYSIS] Consensus remains politically valuable because divergent GST laws can fragment the common market even where legal autonomy exists.
- [LIMIT] GST Council recommendations are neither judicial orders nor constitutional amendments.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - GST COUNCIL AND FISCAL NEGOTIATION

START / CONCEPT: GST Council and fiscal negotiation

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Article 279A • Article 246A • weighted voting • consensus • Mohit Minerals • recommendatory

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Explain composition, voting, recommendation and legislative implementation as separate steps.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Common-market coordination depends politically on consensus despite legal autonomy.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Council recommendations are not binding statutes or judicial orders.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: GST turns tax autonomy into structured bargaining rather than extinguishing federal choice.

SESSION 13 - INTER-STATE WATER DISPUTES: ARTICLE 262

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Inter-State river disputes use a special statutory adjudication route because basins cross political boundaries.

Technical definition: Article 262 authorises parliamentary adjudication and jurisdiction exclusion; the 1956 Act retains dispute-specific tribunals.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

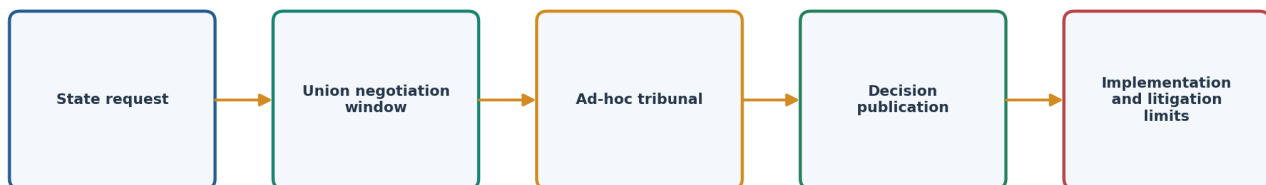
An award needs data, implementation and basin cooperation, not adjudication alone.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 262
- ISRWD Act 1956
- River Boards Act 1956
- tribunal
- jurisdiction exclusion
- basin governance

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 262; define ISRWD Act 1956, connect River Boards Act 1956 with tribunal to explain the mechanism, and use jurisdiction exclusion for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Current inter-State water-dispute architecture



The controlling system remains negotiation followed by dispute-specific tribunal adjudication.

- [FACT] Article 262 permits Parliament to provide adjudication of inter-State river-water disputes and exclude Supreme Court and other court jurisdiction over such disputes.
- [FACT] Parliament enacted the River Boards Act, 1956 and Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956.
- [FACT] The existing Act uses dispute-specific tribunals; awards become final and binding under the statutory scheme after publication.
- [CURRENT] The 2019 Amendment Bill proposed a dispute-resolution committee and a permanent tribunal with benches. It passed Lok Sabha, **lapsed with dissolution of the Seventeenth Lok Sabha**, and is not law. Official departmental material later described a revised proposal; it too must not be presented as enacted law.
- [LIMIT] Do not describe a permanent tribunal as current law.

Structural weaknesses and reform

Weakness	Consequence	Reform direction
Delayed tribunal constitution and adjudication	Conflict hardens politically	Firm statutory stages and staffed benches
Data disagreement	Competing hydrological narratives	Independent shared basin data
Implementation conflict	Award does not end politics	Basin institutions and compliance monitoring
Climate variability	Historical flows become unstable	Adaptive review and ecological-flow planning
Jurisdiction exclusion	Limited ordinary judicial route	Precise statutory review/implementation design

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - INTER-STATE WATER DISPUTES: ARTICLE 262

START / CONCEPT: Inter-State water disputes: Article 262

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Article 262 · ISRWD Act 1956 · River Boards Act 1956 · tribunal · jurisdiction exclusion · basin governance

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Trace negotiation, tribunal reference, decision publication and implementation.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Specialisation can reduce parallel litigation but delays and compliance disputes persist.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: no permanent tribunal is current law.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: An award needs data, implementation and basin cooperation, not adjudication alone.

SESSION 14 - INTER-STATE COUNCIL AND ZONAL COUNCILS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The Inter-State Council and Zonal Councils are intergovernmental forums with different constitutional and statutory foundations.

Technical definition: Article 263 enables the Inter-State Council; the States Reorganisation Act creates five Zonal Councils; the NEC has a separate statute.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

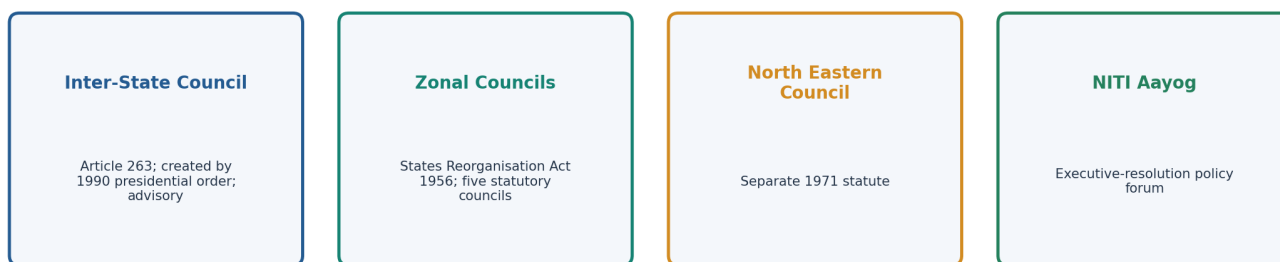
Legal status determines mandate, not whether a body is commonly called a council.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 263
- Inter-State Council
- Zonal Councils
- States Reorganisation Act 1956
- North Eastern Council
- consultation

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 263; define Inter-State Council, connect Zonal Councils with States Reorganisation Act 1956 to explain the mechanism, and use North Eastern Council for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Intergovernmental forums: status matters



The Inter-State Council, Zonal Councils, NEC and NITI differ in constitutional and statutory status.

Inter-State Council

- [FACT] Article 263 authorises the President to establish a Council if public interest would be served.
- [FACT] The Council may inquire into and advise on disputes, investigate common-interest subjects and recommend coordination.
- [FACT] It was established by presidential order in 1990 following Sarkaria Commission recommendation.
- [FACT] It is advisory; unlike an Article 131 judgment, its recommendations are not binding.
- [CURRENT] Full Council meetings remain infrequent; recent visible activity is stronger in Zonal Councils and their standing committees.

Zonal Councils and NEC

Body	Legal status	Chair / character
Five Zonal Councils	Statutory, States Reorganisation Act 1956	Union Home Minister; advisory and regional
North Eastern Council	Statutory, NEC Act 1971	Separate institution, not a sixth Zonal Council
NITI Aayog	Executive resolution	PM-chaired national policy forum
National Security Council	Executive/non-statutory	Security advisory architecture

- [CURRENT] Official ISCS records show the 26th Central Zonal Council meeting on 19 May 2026, the 22nd Northern Zonal Standing Committee on 19 June, the 15th Eastern Zonal Standing Committee on 7 July and the 31st Southern Zonal Council on 20 August 2026. This demonstrates active regional coordination even while the full ISC remains underused.
- [ANALYSIS] The design gap is not absence of forums but irregular escalation from regional problem-solving to national intergovernmental settlement.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - INTER-STATE COUNCIL AND ZONAL COUNCILS

START / CONCEPT: Inter-State Council and Zonal Councils

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Article 263 • Inter-State Council • Zonal Councils • States Reorganisation Act 1956 • North Eastern Council • consultation

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Classify each forum by source, composition, scale and recommendatory function.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Regional councils can solve operational disputes while the ISC addresses national coordination.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The NEC is not a sixth Zonal Council and Zonal Councils are not constitutional bodies.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Legal status determines mandate, not whether a body is commonly called a council.

SESSION 15 - FULL FAITH AND CREDIT: ARTICLE 261

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Article 261 supports legal unity by requiring nationwide recognition of public acts, records and judicial proceedings.

Technical definition: Parliament may prescribe proof and effect, while civil judgments are executable across India according to law.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Full faith and credit under Article 261 preserves recognition across State borders without merging jurisdictions.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Article 261**
- **full faith and credit**
- **public acts**
- **public records**
- **judicial proceedings**
- **civil judgments**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 261; define full faith and credit, connect public acts with public records to explain the mechanism, and use judicial proceedings for the decisive comparison or qualification.

- [FACT] Public acts, records and judicial proceedings of the Union and every State receive full faith and credit throughout India.
- [FACT] Parliament may prescribe the manner of proof and effect.
- [FACT] Final judgments or orders delivered or passed by civil courts in any part of India are capable of execution anywhere according to law.
- [LIMIT] Clause (3) specifically concerns civil judgments; do not convert it into a claim that every criminal or penal rule has extra-territorial operation.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FULL FAITH AND CREDIT: ARTICLE 261

START / CONCEPT: Full faith and credit: Article 261

|

↓

EXACT TERMS: Article 261 · full faith and credit · public acts · public records · judicial proceedings · civil judgments

|

↓

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Separate recognition, proof/effect and execution of civil judgments.

|

↓

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Citizens and institutions can rely on legal acts beyond the originating State.

|

↓

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not convert clause 3 into nationwide operation of every criminal or penal law.

|

↓

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Full faith and credit under Article 261 preserves recognition across State borders without merging jurisdictions.

SESSION 16 - FREEDOM OF TRADE, COMMERCE AND INTERCOURSE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Freedom of trade, commerce and intercourse under Part XIII creates an integrated market with bounded regulation and taxation.

Technical definition: Articles 301-304 prohibit protectionist discrimination, not every tax or public-interest restriction.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Freedom of trade, commerce and intercourse secures economic unity through non-discrimination, not tax immunity.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Article 301
- Article 302
- Article 303
- Article 304(a)
- Article 304(b)
- Jindal Stainless

How to use them: Frame the answer through Article 301; define Article 302, connect Article 303 with Article 304(a) to explain the mechanism, and use Article 304(b) for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Part XIII common-market design

Article 301
Freedom of trade, commerce and intercourse

Article 302
Parliament may restrict in public interest

Article 303
No preference; scarcity exception for Parliament

Article 304(a)
State tax must avoid hostile discrimination

Article 304(b)
Reasonable restriction with previous presidential sanction

Jindal Stainless
No compensatory-tax doctrine; discrimination is central

Article	Rule
301	Trade, commerce and intercourse throughout India shall be free
302	Parliament may impose public-interest restrictions
303(1)	Parliament and States generally cannot prefer one State over another
303(2)	Parliament may depart to address scarcity of goods
304(a)	State tax on imported goods must not discriminate against them vis-a-vis similar local goods
304(b)	State may impose reasonable public-interest restrictions with previous presidential sanction
307	Parliament may appoint an implementing authority

Judicial evolution

- *Atiabari Tea* (1961) focused on direct and immediate restrictions.
- *Automobile Transport* (1962) developed a regulatory/compensatory approach.
- [FACT] *Jindal Stainless* (2016, nine judges) rejected the compensatory-tax doctrine as lacking textual foundation.
- [FACT] Article 301 does not create a tax-free market; the central tax question is hostile or protectionist discrimination under Article 304(a).
- [FACT] Article 304(a) and 304(b) operate distinctly; public-interest restriction cannot cure a discriminatory tax.
- [ANALYSIS] GST supplied fiscal integration that Part XIII litigation alone could not administratively achieve.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FREEDOM OF TRADE, COMMERCE AND INTERCOURSE

START / CONCEPT: Freedom of trade, commerce and intercourse

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Article 301 • Article 302 • Article 303 • Article 304(a) • Article 304(b) • *Jindal Stainless*

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Test competence, discrimination, public interest and previous presidential sanction where applicable.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: States retain regulatory space while hostile interstate protectionism is constrained.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: article 304(a) taxation and Article 304(b) restrictions are distinct routes.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Freedom of trade, commerce and intercourse secures economic unity through non-discrimination, not tax immunity.

SESSION 17 - MINOR MINERALS: UNION NOTIFICATION, STATE RULE-MAKING

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Minor-mineral regulation divides category control and concession rule-making between Union law and States.

Technical definition: The MMDR Act lets the Centre notify minor minerals while Section 15 empowers States to regulate concessions.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Central classification power does not erase State rule-making authority.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- MMDR Act
- minor minerals
- Section 3(e)
- Section 15
- Central notification

How to use them: Frame the answer through MMDR Act; define minor minerals, connect Section 3(e) with Section 15 to explain the mechanism, and use Central notification for the decisive comparison or qualification.

- [FACT] The Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957 is parliamentary legislation under Union control over mineral regulation to the declared extent.
- [FACT] Section 3(e) empowers the Central Government to notify additional minerals as "minor minerals."
- [FACT] Section 15 empowers State Governments to make rules regulating quarry leases, mining leases and other concessions for minor minerals.
- [LIMIT] Central power to define/notify the category does not eliminate State rule-making for concessions.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - MINOR MINERALS: UNION NOTIFICATION, STATE RULE-MAKING

START / CONCEPT: Minor minerals: Union notification, State rule-making

|
v

EXACT TERMS: MMDR Act · minor minerals · Section 3(e) · Section 15 · Central notification

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Identify the parliamentary framework, notification power and State concession rules.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The arrangement demonstrates layered rather than exclusive regulatory control.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not infer that State Governments have no power merely because the Centre defines the category.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Central classification power does not erase State rule-making authority.

SESSION 18 - COMMISSIONS ON CENTRE-STATE RELATIONS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Rajamannar, Sarkaria and Punchhi offer different diagnoses of Union-State imbalance and cooperation.

Technical definition: Centre-State relations commissions provide reform recommendations that require constitutional, statutory or executive adoption before acquiring legal force.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Commission proposals are marks-worthy when tied to the exact diagnosed institution.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

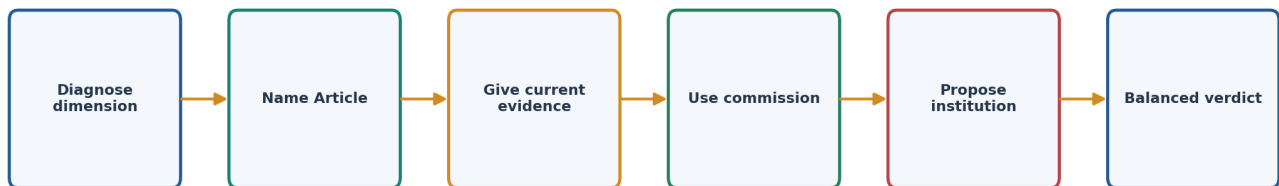
- Rajamannar Committee
- Sarkaria Commission
- Punchhi Commission
- Article 356
- Governor neutrality
- Inter-State Council

How to use them: Frame the answer through Rajamannar Committee; define Sarkaria Commission, connect Punchhi Commission with Article 356 to explain the mechanism, and use Governor neutrality for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Body	Orientation	High-yield recommendations
Rajamannar Committee (1969)	Strong State autonomy	Curtail Union power, strengthen ISC, review Articles 356-357
Sarkaria Commission (1983-88)	Cooperative federalism within a strong Union	Article 356 last resort; neutral Governors; consult States on Concurrent laws; permanent ISC
Punchhi Commission (2007-10)	Modernise intergovernmental machinery	Governor norms, stronger ISC, localised emergency concept, clearer consultation

Trust-building reform stack

Trust-building answer spine



Trust is an institutional product of diagnosis, constitutional anchoring, evidence, commission guidance and a balanced reform.

1. Convene the Inter-State Council regularly with published follow-up.
2. Consult States before major Concurrent-field legislation.
3. Use Governors as neutral constitutional heads, with reasoned and prompt decisions.
4. Protect predictable tax devolution and improve transparency of cesses/surcharges.
5. Make centrally sponsored schemes flexible and jointly designed.
6. Strengthen GST dispute resolution and preserve consensus practice.
7. Create shared river-basin data and enforceable implementation institutions.
8. Clarify CBI accountability and consent protocols by statute.

Core verdict: Trust is not goodwill. It is the repeated institutional experience that consultation occurs before compulsion, reasons accompany discretion, and agreed fiscal rules are honoured.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - COMMISSIONS ON CENTRE-STATE RELATIONS

START / CONCEPT: Commissions on Centre-State relations

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Rajamannar Committee · Sarkaria Commission · Punchhi Commission · Article 356 · Governor neutrality · Inter-State Council

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Match each commission to autonomy, cooperative safeguards or modern institutional reform.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The recurring reform theme is consultation before compulsion and reasoned, reviewable discretion.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not present unimplemented commission recommendations as binding law.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Commission proposals are marks-worthy when tied to the exact diagnosed institution.

POLITY HOSTILE SEMANTIC-REVIEW CORE CONTROL

- **Must remember:** Keep four owned dimensions separate: legislative relations under Articles 245-255, administrative relations under Articles 256-263 and 355/365, financial relations under Articles 268-293, and inter-State coordination under Articles 261-263 and 301-307.
- **Close distinction:** Article 254 repugnancy is principally a Concurrent-List conflict rule; pith and substance tests competence, Article 262 permits statutory exclusion for defined river disputes, and Article 263 creates an enabling power rather than a self-executing adjudicatory council.
- **Legal/source limit:** Special Reference No. 1 of 2025 rejects rigid judicial timelines and deemed assent, recognises Article 200 discretion, and permits only a limited mandamus against prolonged, unexplained and indefinite inaction. Do not continue the displaced April 2025 timeline rule.

Semantic-completeness ownership and PYQ control

- **Legislative relations:** Articles 245-255, the Seventh Schedule and Articles

246A/248 establish territorial reach, distribution, GST competence, residue and repugnancy. Parliament enters the State field only through the distinct routes in Articles 249, 250, 252, 253 and 356.

- **Conflict doctrines:** pith and substance tests true character; territorial

nexus tests State-law reach; colourable legislation tests disguised incompetence; harmonious construction seeks coexistence; Article 254 resolves repugnancy, including the limited President-assented State-law exception in clause (2).

- **Administrative relations:** Articles 256-257 directions, Article 258/258A

entrustment, Article 261 full faith and credit, Article 263 coordination, Article 312 All-India Services, and Articles 355/365 must retain separate triggers and consequences.

- **CBI boundary:** Section 6 of the Delhi Special Police Establishment Act requires

State consent for ordinary CBI exercise of powers in a State. Withdrawal of general consent does not displace constitutional-court power under Articles 32/226 or automatically nullify every lawfully commenced investigation.

- **Financial relations:** Articles 268-281, 292-293, Article 246A/269A/279A,

the divisible pool, grants, cesses/surcharges, borrowing and Finance Commission recommendations must be analysed as distinct vertical and horizontal mechanisms.

- **Inter-State relations:** Article 262 plus the 1956 water-disputes statute,

Article 263, statutory Zonal Councils, the North-Eastern Council, Article 261 and Articles 301-307 create different adjudicatory, consultative and market routes.

- **Commissions:** Rajamannar, Sarkaria and Punchhi recommendations are named

reform evidence, not binding constitutional amendments. Article 356 remains a last-resort control under S.R. Bommai.

- **Current assent law:** Special Reference No. 1 of 2025 holds that the Governor has three Article 200 options, acts with discretion rather than State-Cabinet advice for that choice, and is not subject to merits review; only prolonged, unexplained and indefinite inaction permits limited mandamus to act.
- **Current fiscal control:** the Sixteenth Finance Commission submitted its report on 17 November 2025 for 2026-31 and retained forty-one per cent vertical devolution. Mohit Minerals continues to treat GST Council recommendations as persuasive rather than binding.
- **Four-ledger/PYQ control:** all four relation dimensions, doctrines, commissions, institutions, live legal status and the eleven direct/supporting 2018-2025 demands were reconciled; federal/unitary taxonomy stays in Topic 12.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Original hard MCQ set - strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation

OM1. Article 245

Which statement is correct?

- A. A parliamentary law is not invalid merely for extra-territorial operation. B. Article 245 concerns only taxation. C. A State law can never have extra-State effect. D. Parliament needs State consent for extra-territorial law.

Answer: A.

Article 245(2) supplies the rule; State reach depends on territorial nexus.

OM2. List hierarchy

Which is the standard current examination count?

- A. Union 98, State 59, Concurrent 52 B. Union 100, State 61, Concurrent 52 C. Union 100, State 60, Concurrent 52 D. Union 97, State 66, Concurrent 47

Answer: B.

Use 100/61/52 while recognising retained omitted/inserted numbering.

OM3. 42nd Amendment

Which subject was moved from State to Concurrent List by the 42nd Amendment?

- A. Public health B. Agriculture C. Education D. Police

Answer: C.

Education was one of five transferred subjects.

OM4. Residuary power

Residuary legislative power belongs to:

- A. Supreme Court B. Inter-State Council C. States D. Parliament

Answer: D.

Article 248 and Union Entry 97 place it with Parliament.

OM5. Article 249

The special trigger is:

- A. Rajya Sabha national-interest resolution by prescribed majority B. Lok Sabha simple majority C. Two-State request D. National Emergency

Answer: A.

It is a federal role of Rajya Sabha and does not require Emergency.

OM6. Article 252

Which is correct?

A. It requires presidential rule. B. Two or more States initiate; Parliament alone later amends/repeals. C. A State may unilaterally repeal it. D. It applies automatically to every State.

Answer: B.

Other States can later adopt the parliamentary law.

OM7. Article 253

Parliament can legislate on a State field to:

A. create a local body B. alter a State Budget C. implement a treaty or international decision D. remove a Governor

Answer: C.

Article 253 is an express treaty-implementation route.

OM8. Article 250

A State-field law made during National Emergency becomes inoperative:

A. only after State repeal B. immediately after Emergency C. after one year D. six months after Emergency ceases

Answer: D.

The six-month tail permits transition.

OM9. Pith and substance

The doctrine asks:

A. What is the law's true nature? B. Whether Union law is popular C. Whether President agrees D. Whether two States consent

Answer: A.

Incidental encroachment does not defeat a law within competence.

OM10. Harmonious construction

Its principal purpose is to:

A. always invalidate State law B. allow both constitutional fields maximum workable operation C. transfer residue to States D. abolish Article 254

Answer: B.

Supremacy is used after reconciliation fails.

OM11. Article 254

A President-assented State law repugnant on a Concurrent subject:

A. prevails nationally B. cannot be overridden C. may operate in that State until Parliament overrides D. becomes a constitutional amendment

Answer: C.

Article 254(2) is State-specific and subject to later parliamentary law.

OM12. Colourable legislation

Which principle is captured?

A. Form alone decides competence. B. Every overlap is valid. C. President cures all incompetence. D. What cannot be done directly cannot be done indirectly.

Answer: D.

Substance controls over legislative disguise.

OM13. Article 256

States must:

A. ensure compliance with parliamentary and applicable laws B. transfer police to Union C. follow ISC recommendations as binding D. obtain Union approval for every executive act

Answer: A.

Union directions can support this compliance duty.

OM14. Article 365

Which is most accurate?

A. It creates an All-India Service. B. Non-compliance may support a presidential conclusion, but Article 356 safeguards remain. C. It automatically imposes President's Rule. D. It concerns tax sharing.

Answer: B.

The inference is not automatic and Bommai review remains.

OM15. Article 258A

It permits:

A. President to amend State law B. Parliament to dissolve Assembly C. Governor with Union consent to entrust State functions to Union D. ISC to issue binding directions

Answer: C.

Article 258 concerns Union-to-State entrustment; 258A is the reverse.

OM16. All-India Service

Which is not an All-India Service?

A. IPS B. Indian Forest Service C. IAS D. Indian Foreign Service

Answer: D.

The Foreign Service is a Central Civil Service.

OM17. CBI consent

Which is correct?

A. Constitutional courts may order a CBI probe without State consent. B. CBI has a dedicated constitutional article. C. Police is Concurrent List. D. Withdrawal voids all earlier cases automatically.

Answer: A.

Section 6 consent is important but does not bind Article 32/226 courts.

OM18. Article 265

It provides:

A. State borrowing abroad B. no tax except by authority of law C. free inter-State trade D. Finance Commission every five years

Answer: B.

It is the foundational legality rule for taxation.

OM19. Article 269A

It principally concerns:

A. State borrowing B. Union surcharge C. inter-State GST apportionment D. profession tax

Answer: C.

IGST is levied/collected by Union and apportioned.

OM20. Article 271

Which is correct?

A. GST surcharge is unrestricted. B. States impose Union surcharge. C. Surcharge is shared under Article 270. D. Parliament may impose Union-purpose surcharge whose proceeds are not shared.

Answer: D.

Cesses/surcharges outside the pool are a major State grievance.

OM21. Article 275

It concerns:

A. constitutional grants-in-aid B. inter-State water tribunals C. discretionary any-purpose grants only D. external borrowing

Answer: A.

Article 282 is the broad discretionary public-purpose grant provision.

OM22. State borrowing

A State with an outstanding Union loan:

A. requires ISC consent B. needs Union consent for further borrowing, potentially with conditions C. may borrow abroad freely D. cannot borrow at all

Answer: B.

Article 293 is a central fiscal-leverage point.

OM23. 16th FC

Which criterion is new in the 2026-31 horizontal formula?

A. Tax effort B. Urbanisation C. Contribution to GDP D. Fiscal deficit

Answer: C.

Contribution to GDP has 10%; tax effort was removed.

OM24. 16th FC vertical share

The accepted share is:

A. 42% divisible pool B. 50% gross tax C. 40% all receipts D. 41% divisible pool

Answer: D.

Cesses, surcharges and collection cost are outside the divisible pool.

OM25. Water amendment

As of 16 August 2026:

A. The 2019 permanent-tribunal Bill has not become law. B. Article 262 was repealed. C. A permanent tribunal is operational. D. Courts have unrestricted jurisdiction.

Answer: A.

The existing dispute-specific tribunal system remains controlling.

OM26. Inter-State Council

Which is correct?

A. It is created by the States Reorganisation Act. B. Article 263 permits it and a 1990 presidential order established it. C. Its decisions bind like Supreme Court judgments. D. It is chaired by the Chief Justice.

Answer: B.

It is advisory and constitutionally provided.

OM27. Part XIII

After Jindal Stainless, a State tax on imported goods is centrally tested for:

A. quid pro quo B. Finance Commission approval C. hostile/protectionist discrimination under Article 304(a) D. compensatory character

Answer: C.

The nine-judge bench rejected the compensatory-tax doctrine.

OM28. Minor minerals

Which allocation is correct?

A. ISC makes rules. B. States notify minor-mineral category and Union grants leases. C. Only Union has all powers. D. Centre may notify category; States make concession rules under Section 15.

Answer: D.

This is the official 2025 PYQ distinction.

Remedial MCQ loop - strict A -> A -> C -> D rotation

RM1. R-N-S-I-P

Which Article uses a Rajya Sabha national-interest resolution?

A. 249 B. 250 C. 253 D. 252

Answer: A.

Article 249 is not an Emergency provision.

RM2. Repugnancy

Article 254 principally concerns:

A. water disputes B. Concurrent conflict C. Union List D. State borrowing

Answer: B.

First identify competence; then apply repugnancy if relevant.

RM3. Directions

Failure to comply with Union directions:

A. automatically ends Governor tenure B. has no consequence C. may trigger Article 365 inference, subject to Article 356 safeguards D. automatically dissolves Assembly

Answer: C.

Automatic-President's-Rule language is wrong.

RM4. Services

Which is a Central Civil Service, not AIS?

A. IPS B. IAS C. IFoS D. Indian Foreign Service

Answer: D.

The similar initials are a common trap.

RM5. Grants

Article 275 refers to:

A. constitutional grants-in-aid B. foreign borrowing C. GST compensation D. any-purpose discretionary grants

Answer: A.

Article 282 is the broad discretionary provision.

RM6. Institution status

Zonal Councils are:

A. judicial B. statutory C. private D. constitutional

Answer: B.

They arise under the States Reorganisation Act 1956.

RM7. Trade tax

Jindal Stainless rejected:

A. all State taxes B. Article 304(a) C. the compensatory-tax doctrine D. GST

Answer: C.

Non-discriminatory taxation is not automatically barred.

RM8. Water tribunal

The permanent single tribunal is:

A. constitutional body B. created in 1956 C. operational D. a 2019 Bill proposal not enacted by the control date

Answer: D.

Do not turn a Bill into current law.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Routed PYQs with model solutions

PYQ 1 - UPSC GS-II 2019, Q4 - direct

Question: From the resolution of contentious issues regarding distribution of legislative powers by the courts, "Principle of Federal Supremacy" and "Harmonious Construction" have emerged. Explain. **10 marks | 150 words**

Demand decoding: Explain requires a sequential doctrine answer: allocation, reconciliation, irreconcilable conflict and qualified supremacy.

Model solution

The Seventh Schedule distributes legislative fields, but modern laws overlap. Courts therefore reconcile entries before invalidating legislation.

Harmonious construction gives broad meaning to each entry while preserving meaningful operation of both Union and State fields. **Pith and substance** supports this approach: if a law's dominant character lies within competence, incidental encroachment survives.

Federal supremacy operates when reconciliation fails. Article 246 gives Union List predominance through its notwithstanding clause. On a Concurrent subject, Article 254 ordinarily makes parliamentary law prevail over repugnant State law. A State law reserved for and receiving Presidential assent may operate within that State, but Parliament can subsequently override it.

The doctrines are therefore sequential, not contradictory. Harmonious construction protects federal autonomy; supremacy prevents legal paralysis. Sarkaria described federal supremacy as a technique to avoid absurdity and resolve conflict.

Thus, Indian legislative federalism is accommodative in interpretation but Union-weighted at the point of irreconcilable conflict.

Why this earns marks: It defines both doctrines, anchors Articles 246/254 and shows their order rather than listing them.

How to improve this answer: In the exam, draw a three-arrow sequence-pith and substance -> harmonious construction -> Article 254-and retain the Sarkaria line only if space permits.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "From the resolution of contentious issues regarding distribution of legislative powers by the courts, "Principle of Federal Supremacy" and..."

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** The Seventh Schedule distributes legislative fields, but modern laws overlap. Courts therefore reconcile entries before invalidating legislation. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** Thus, Indian legislative federalism is accommodative in interpretation but Union-weighted at the point of irreconcilable conflict. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or

legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It defines both doctrines, anchors Articles 246/254 and shows their order rather than listing them. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication.

Qualification: State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: In the exam, draw a three-arrow sequence-pith and substance -> harmonious construction -> Article 254-and retain the Sarkaria line only if space permits. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "From the resolution of contentious issues regarding distribution of legislative powers by the courts, "Principle of Federal Supremacy" and..."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

PYQ 2 - UPSC GS-II 2020, Q11 - direct

Question: The Indian Constitution exhibits centralising tendencies to maintain unity and integrity of the nation. Elucidate in the perspective of the Epidemic Diseases Act, 1897, the Disaster Management Act, 2005 and the recently passed Farm Acts. **15 marks | 250 words**

Demand decoding: Elucidate requires showing how emergency and Concurrent-field laws reveal centralising capacity, with both necessity and federal cost.

Model solution

India's holding-together federation gives the Union exceptional capacity to coordinate national crises and markets. Recent legislation showed both the necessity and federal cost of that design.

During COVID-19, the Union used the Disaster Management Act, 2005 for nationwide directions, while the Epidemic Diseases Act, 1897 operated through State measures. Uniform restrictions, procurement and movement rules supplied scale but also compressed State policy space in public health, a State subject.

The 2020 Farm Acts relied substantially on Concurrent List Entry 33 concerning trade in foodstuffs, yet affected agriculture and markets associated with State List Entries 14 and 28. States argued that legal competence was being used without adequate federal consultation. The Acts were repealed in 2021, demonstrating political federalism and mobilisation.

Other centralising tools include residuary power, Articles 249, 250, 253 and 356, All-India Services, conditional schemes and fiscal dependence. However, centralisation is not unlimited: *S.R. Bommai* makes federalism Basic Structure; courts apply pith and substance; GST requires shared institutions; States retain electoral and implementation power.

Therefore, national coordination may justify central legislation, but legitimacy requires necessity, clear List competence, consultation and proportionality. Unity is strengthened when Union capacity works through cooperative institutions rather than treating States as implementing agencies.

Why this earns marks: It uses the named statutes and Farm Acts, connects List entries, and balances centralisation with Bommai and political repeal.

How to improve this answer: Compress the general centralising-tool list to one sentence and spend the saved words on consultation and proportionality, which answer the evaluative edge.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "The Indian Constitution exhibits centralising tendencies to maintain unity and integrity of the nation. Elucidate in the perspective of the Epidemic..."

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** India's holding-together federation gives the Union exceptional capacity to coordinate national crises and markets. Recent legislation showed both the necessity and federal cost of that design. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It uses the named statutes and Farm Acts, connects List entries, and balances centralisation with Bommai and political repeal. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: Compress the general centralising-tool list to one sentence and spend the saved words on consultation and proportionality, which answer the evaluative edge. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "The Indian Constitution exhibits centralising tendencies to maintain unity and integrity of the nation. Elucidate in the perspective of the Epidemic..."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

PYQ 3 - UPSC GS-II 2021, Q11 - supporting

Question: The jurisdiction of the Central Bureau of Investigation regarding lodging an FIR and conducting a probe within a particular State is being questioned by various States. However, the power of States to withhold consent to the CBI is not absolute. Explain with special reference to the federal character of India. **15 marks | 250 words**

Demand decoding: Explain the statutory consent rule, its constitutional exceptions and why neither State consent nor Union investigation is absolute.

Model solution

Police is a State subject, while the CBI exercises investigative powers through the Delhi Special Police Establishment Act, 1946. Section 6 therefore requires State consent for DSPE jurisdiction within a State.

General consent permits routine registration; withdrawal ordinarily requires case-specific consent for fresh cases. This is a real federal safeguard against an unrestricted parallel central police force.

The safeguard is not absolute. The Supreme Court under Article 32 and High Courts under Article 226 may order a CBI probe without State consent to secure fair investigation and fundamental rights. Withdrawal also does not automatically nullify every validly commenced case, and territorial or accused-specific questions can affect jurisdiction.

In *State of West Bengal v. Union of India* (2024), the Supreme Court rejected the Union's preliminary objection and allowed the State's Article 131 suit to proceed; it did not finally decide all substantive claims.

The federal balance requires State police autonomy, national coordination for cross-border corruption and judicial power where local investigation is compromised. A dedicated CBI statute, transparent consent protocols and independent appointment/accountability mechanisms would reduce political confrontation.

Thus, consent is constitutionally significant statutory federalism, but it cannot override constitutional-court power.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes DSPE consent, constitutional-court power and the limited 2024 West Bengal ruling.

How to improve this answer: Add a two-column consent/exception mini-table in rough work; do not claim the 2024 ruling finally decided the merits.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "The jurisdiction of the Central Bureau of Investigation regarding lodging an FIR and conducting a probe within a particular State is being questioned..."

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Police is a State subject, while the CBI exercises investigative powers through the Delhi Special Police Establishment Act, 1946. Section 6 therefore requires State consent for DSPE jurisdiction within a State. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** General consent permits routine registration; withdrawal ordinarily requires case-specific consent for fresh cases. This is a real federal safeguard against an unrestricted parallel central police force. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** In *State of West Bengal v. Union of India* (2024), the Supreme Court rejected the Union's preliminary objection and allowed the State's Article 131 suit to proceed; it did not finally decide all substantive claims. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Thus, consent is constitutionally significant statutory federalism, but it cannot override constitutional-court power. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It distinguishes DSPE consent, constitutional-court power and the limited 2024 West Bengal ruling. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "The jurisdiction of the Central Bureau of Investigation regarding lodging an FIR and conducting a probe within a particular State is being questioned..."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

PYQ 4 - UPSC GS-II 2022, Q13 - supporting

Question: While the national political parties in India favour centralisation, the regional parties are in favour of State autonomy. Comment. **15 marks | 250 words**

Demand decoding: Comment requires testing the proposition as a political tendency, then qualifying it through changing party incentives and institutions.

Model solution

The claim captures a recurrent incentive, not an iron law. National parties seek uniform programmes, national markets and coordinated security, and therefore often favour Union legislation, centrally sponsored schemes and common institutions. Regional parties derive authority from territorially concentrated mandates and more often demand fiscal space, linguistic recognition, control over State subjects and restraint in the use of Governors and central agencies.

Yet party position changes with office. A national party governing a State may resist Union encroachment, while a regional party participating in a Union coalition may support central measures. Coalition governments, the GST Council and Rajya Sabha bargaining have periodically enlarged State influence. Conversely, a dominant parliamentary majority can reduce negotiated federalism.

The constitutional answer is institutional rather than partisan: regular Inter-State Council consultation, meaningful scrutiny of Concurrent legislation, predictable Finance Commission transfers and neutral constitutional offices. Thus, party geography shapes federal preferences, but constitutional forums must prevent temporary electoral advantage from defining Centre-State balance.

Why this earns marks: It explains national/regional incentives, supplies coalition and Rajya Sabha counter-evidence, and avoids treating party labels as permanent doctrine.

How to improve this answer: Use one concrete coalition-era illustration if confidently recalled; otherwise preserve the office-dependent qualification rather than inventing an example.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "While the national political parties in India favour centralisation, the regional parties are in favour of State autonomy. Comment."

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It explains national/regional incentives, supplies coalition and Rajya Sabha counter-evidence, and avoids treating party labels as permanent doctrine. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: Use one concrete coalition-era illustration if confidently recalled; otherwise preserve the office-dependent qualification rather than inventing an example. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "While the national political parties in India favour centralisation, the regional parties are in favour of State autonomy. Comment."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

PYQ 5 - UPSC GS-II 2023, Q13 - supporting

Question: Account for the legal and political factors responsible for the reduced frequency of use of Article 356 by the Union Governments since the mid-1990s. **15 marks | 250 words**

Demand decoding: Account for requires causal explanation of both legal and political factors behind reduced Article 356 use.

Model solution

The decline reflects both judicial discipline and a changed party system. In *S.R. Bommai* (1994), the Supreme Court made Article 356 proclamations reviewable, required relevant material, protected floor tests as the normal majority test and permitted restoration of a dismissed government. Parliamentary approval and the possibility of judicial invalidation raised the legal cost of partisan dismissal.

Politically, coalition governments after 1989 depended on regional parties, whose bargaining power discouraged arbitrary action against States. Stronger regional mandates, public criticism of central misuse and the reputational cost of federal confrontation also mattered. Later single-party Union majorities did not erase these constraints because *Bommai* doctrine, electoral competition and the Rajya Sabha continued to impose checks.

The decline does not mean Centre-State conflict disappeared; disputes shifted toward Governors, investigations, finance and assent. Article 356 remains an emergency remedy, while Article 365 non-compliance is only relevant material. The reduced frequency therefore shows constitutional law and political federalisation reinforcing each other.

Why this earns marks: It links *Bommai* safeguards with coalition/regional-party incentives and distinguishes declining proclamations from continuing federal conflict.

How to improve this answer: Organise the body under Legal and Political subheads and end by naming the shift toward Governors, finance and agencies.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Account for the legal and political factors responsible for the reduced frequency of use of Article 356 by the Union Governments since the mid-1990s."

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It links *Bommai* safeguards with coalition/regional-party incentives and distinguishes declining proclamations from continuing federal conflict. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: Organise the body under Legal and Political subheads and end by naming the shift toward Governors, finance and agencies. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Account for the legal and political factors responsible for the reduced frequency of use of Article 356 by the Union Governments since the mid-1990s."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

PYQ 6 - UPSC GS-II 2023, Q15 - direct

Question: Explain the significance of the 101st Constitutional Amendment Act. To what extent does it reflect the accommodative spirit of federalism? **15 marks | 250 words**

Demand decoding: Explain significance and assess extent: first map the 101st Amendment, then evaluate how far its design is accommodative.

Model solution

The 101st Amendment created a shared constitutional tax field rather than merely altering rates. Article 246A gives Parliament and State legislatures GST competence; Article 269A governs inter-State GST apportionment; Article 279A creates the GST Council with Union and State representation. It replaced multiple indirect taxes with a destination-based system and supported a common market.

Its accommodative character lies in compulsory bargaining: the Union has one-third voting weight, States collectively two-thirds, and decisions require a three-fourths weighted majority. Consensus practice, compensation arrangements and joint administration converted fiscal autonomy into negotiated interdependence. *Mohit Minerals* further held Council recommendations recommendatory, preserving legislative authority at both levels.

Accommodation remains incomplete. States lost independent rate space, compensation disputes exposed dependence, and unequal revenue capacity affects bargaining power. A common tax can become centralising if consultation weakens. The Amendment is therefore a major example of cooperative fiscal federalism, but its success depends on consensus, transparent data, credible dispute resolution and respect for State legislative choice.

Why this earns marks: It cites Articles 246A/269A/279A, weighted voting, consensus and *Mohit Minerals*, followed by limits on State fiscal space.

How to improve this answer: Include the one-third/two-thirds/three-fourths voting formula; omit rate trivia unless the question asks current GST reform.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Explain the significance of the 101st Constitutional Amendment Act. To what extent does it reflect the accommodative spirit of federalism?".

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It cites Articles 246A/269A/279A, weighted voting, consensus and *Mohit Minerals*, followed by limits on State fiscal space. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: Include the one-third/two-thirds/three-fourths voting formula; omit rate trivia unless the question asks current GST reform. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Explain the significance of the 101st Constitutional Amendment Act. To what extent does it reflect the accommodative spirit of federalism?".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

PYQ 7 - UPSC GS-II 2024, Q13 - direct

Question: What changes has the Union Government recently introduced in the domain of Centre-State relations? Suggest measures to be adopted to build the trust between the Centre and the States and for strengthening federalism. **15 marks | 250 words**

Demand decoding: Suggest demands two balanced halves: identify recent changes and offer institution-matched trust remedies.

Model solution

Centre-State relations have shifted from plan-era bargaining to a mixed Finance Commission-GST-NITI architecture, while administrative and legislative disputes have intensified.

Changes: The Planning Commission was replaced by NITI Aayog; the 14th Finance Commission increased untied devolution, followed by 41% under later Commissions. GST pooled indirect-tax autonomy through a constitutional Council. Centrally sponsored schemes, cesses and surcharges, borrowing conditions and central agencies continue to shape State choices. Governor assent, CBI consent and Concurrent-field legislation have become recurrent flashpoints.

Trust measures:

1. Convene the Inter-State Council regularly and publish implementation reports.
2. Consult States before major Concurrent List laws.
3. Follow Sarkaria/Punchhi norms for politically neutral Governors and reasoned action.
4. Reduce reliance on cesses outside the divisible pool and ensure predictable transfers.
5. Design schemes jointly with flexible State components.
6. Use consensus and a credible dispute process in the GST Council.
7. Clarify CBI powers and consent through comprehensive legislation.
8. Build shared river-basin data and compliance institutions.

S.R. Bommai makes federalism Basic Structure, but judicial protection alone cannot create cooperation.

Trust is an institutional output: States must repeatedly experience consultation before compulsion, fiscal predictability and neutral use of constitutional offices.

Why this earns marks: It covers fiscal, legislative and administrative change and ties each remedy to ISC, GST, Finance Commission, Governor or CBI architecture.

How to improve this answer: Pair every diagnosed deficit with one remedy; avoid an unstructured reform list and keep the conclusion focused on repeated institutional experience.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "What changes has the Union Government recently introduced in the domain of Centre-State relations? Suggest measures to be adopted to build the trust...".

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Centre-State relations have shifted from plan-era bargaining to a mixed Finance Commission-GST-NITI architecture, while administrative and legislative disputes have intensified. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Convene the Inter-State Council regularly and publish implementation reports. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Consult States before major Concurrent List laws. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy

implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** Follow Sarkaria/Punchhi norms for politically neutral Governors and reasoned action. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Reduce reliance on cesses outside the divisible pool and ensure predictable transfers. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "What changes has the Union Government recently introduced in the domain of Centre-State relations? Suggest measures to be adopted to build the trust...".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

PYQ 8 - UPSC Prelims 2024, Q75 - official key

Question: Which one of the following statements is correct as per the Constitution of India?

A. Inter-State trade and commerce is a State subject under the State List. B. Inter-State migration is a State subject under the State List. C. Inter-State quarantine is a Union subject under the Union List. D. Corporation tax is a State subject under the State List.

Answer: C. OFFICIAL UPSC SET-A KEY.

Union List Entry 81 covers inter-State migration and inter-State quarantine; Entry 42 covers inter-State trade and commerce; corporation tax is also a Union subject.

Demand decoding: Treat "Which one of the following statements is correct as per the Constitution of India? A. Inter-..." as a definition, category, constitutional boundary, institution, mechanism and source-date-status problem. Test each statement.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Which one of the following statements is correct as per the Constitution of India? A. Inter-State trade and commerce is a State subject under the...".

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ 8 - UPSC Prelims 2024, Q75 - official key **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** A. Inter-State trade and commerce is a State subject under the State List. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** B. Inter-State migration is a State subject under the State List. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** C. Inter-State quarantine is a Union subject under the Union List. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** D. Corporation tax is a State subject under the State List. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Which one of the following statements is correct as per the Constitution of India? A. Inter-State trade and commerce is a State subject under the..."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Fix the comparison axis; separate social category from legal status, right from institution and scheme from outcome; test the closest homogenisation, causation or stale-data distractor.

Why this earns marks: It prevents a familiar label or aggregate statistic from replacing the exact concept, institutional mandate, mechanism or evidence status.

How to improve this answer: For "Which one of the following statements is correct as per the Constitution of India? A. Inter-...", state why the nearest distractor fails on definition, group variation, causation, constitutional boundary, date or status.

PYQ 9 - UPSC GS-II 2025, Q14 - direct

Question: Examine the evolving pattern of Centre-State financial relations in the context of planned development in India. How far have the recent reforms impacted the fiscal federalism in India? **15 marks | 250 words**

Demand decoding: Examine requires a chronological fiscal transition, assessment of reforms and a graded verdict on practical autonomy.

Model solution

Centre-State finance has evolved from discretionary plan bargaining toward a more rules-based but still Union-dependent architecture.

During planned development, the Planning Commission and National Development Council shaped plan assistance, while Article 282 grants allowed broad executive discretion. The Finance Commission handled constitutional tax devolution and grants, producing parallel transfer channels.

Post-2015 reforms changed this pattern. NITI Aayog replaced the Planning Commission without assuming devolution powers. The 14th Finance Commission raised the States' tax share to 42%; later Commissions use 41%. GST pooled Union and State indirect taxes through Articles 246A, 269A and 279A, creating a common market and shared decision forum. The 16th Finance Commission retains 41% for 2026-31 and balances income distance with population, demographic, ecological and GDP-contribution criteria.

Reforms improved transparency, untied resources and institutional bargaining. *Mohit Minerals* preserves legislative autonomy by treating GST Council recommendations as non-binding.

However, vertical imbalance persists. Cesses and surcharges remain outside the divisible pool; centrally sponsored schemes impose conditions; GST narrowed independent rate space; Article 293 borrowing consent creates leverage.

Thus, fiscal federalism is more rules-based but not fiscally equal. Protecting the divisible pool, predictable schemes, robust GST dispute resolution and stronger State revenue capacity are necessary for meaningful autonomy.

Why this earns marks: It connects plan-era discretion, Finance Commission devolution, GST and NITI with cesses, schemes and Article 293 constraints.

How to improve this answer: Use a three-stage timeline-Planning era -> post-2015 -> 16th FC-and distinguish divisible-pool share from gross Union tax revenue.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Examine the evolving pattern of Centre-State financial relations in the context of planned development in India. How far have the recent reforms...".

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Centre-State finance has evolved from discretionary plan bargaining toward a more rules-based but still Union-dependent architecture. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Reforms improved transparency, untied resources and institutional bargaining. Mohit Minerals preserves legislative autonomy by treating GST Council recommendations as non-binding. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It connects plan-era discretion, Finance Commission devolution, GST and NITI with cesses, schemes and Article 293 constraints. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: Use a three-stage timeline-Planning era -> post-2015 -> 16th FC-and distinguish divisible-pool share from gross Union tax revenue. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Examine the evolving pattern of Centre-State financial relations in the context of planned development in India. How far have the recent reforms...".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

PYQ 10 - UPSC Prelims 2025, Q53 - official key

Question: With reference to India, consider the following:

1. The Inter-State Council
2. The National Security Council
3. Zonal Councils

How many of the above were established as per provisions of the Constitution of India?

A. Only one B. Only two C. All the three D. None

Answer: A. OFFICIAL UPSC SET-A KEY.

Article 263 provides for establishment of the Inter-State Council. Zonal Councils are statutory and the National Security Council is executive/non-statutory.

Demand decoding: Treat "With reference to India, consider the following: 1. The Inter-State Council 2. The National..." as a definition, category, constitutional boundary, institution, mechanism and source-date-status problem. Test each statement.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "With reference to India, consider the following: 1. The Inter-State Council 2. The National Security Council 3. Zonal Councils How many of the above...".

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ 10 - UPSC Prelims 2025, Q53 - official key **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** How many of the above were established as per provisions of the Constitution of India? **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Article 263 provides for establishment of the Inter-State Council. Zonal Councils are statutory and the National Security Council is executive/non-statutory. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "With reference to India, consider the following: 1. The Inter-State Council 2. The National Security Council 3. Zonal Councils How many of the above...".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Fix the comparison axis; separate social category from legal status, right from institution and scheme from outcome; test the closest homogenisation, causation or stale-data distractor.

Why this earns marks: It prevents a familiar label or aggregate statistic from replacing the exact concept, institutional mandate, mechanism or evidence status.

How to improve this answer: For "With reference to India, consider the following: 1. The Inter-State Council 2. The National...", state why the nearest distractor fails on definition, group variation, causation, constitutional boundary, date or status.

PYQ 11 - UPSC Prelims 2025, Q89 - official key

Question: Consider the following statements:

Statement I: In India, State Governments have no power for making rules for grant of concessions in respect of extraction of minor minerals even though such minerals are located in their territories. Statement II: In India, the Central Government has the power to notify minor minerals under the relevant law.

Which one of the following is correct?

A. Both statements are correct and Statement II explains Statement I B. Both statements are correct but Statement II does not explain Statement I C. Statement I is correct but Statement II is not correct D. Statement I is not correct but Statement II is correct

Answer: D. OFFICIAL UPSC SET-A KEY.

The Centre can notify minor minerals under Section 3(e) of the MMDR Act, while States make concession rules under Section 15.

Original Mains practice with examiner-grade models

Demand decoding: Treat "Consider the following statements: Statement I: In India, State Governments have no power for..." as a definition, category, constitutional boundary, institution, mechanism and source-date-status problem. Test each statement.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Consider the following statements: Statement I: In India, State Governments have no power for making rules for grant of concessions in respect of..."

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** PYQ 11 - UPSC Prelims 2025, Q89 - official key **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** Statement I: In India, State Governments have no power for making rules for grant of concessions in respect of extraction of minor minerals even though such minerals are located in their territories. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** Statement II: In India, the Central Government has the power to notify minor minerals under the relevant law. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** A. Both statements are correct and Statement II explains Statement I **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 5. Claim and named evidence:** B. Both statements are correct but Statement II does not explain Statement I **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Consider the following statements: Statement I: In India, State Governments have no power for making rules for grant of concessions in respect of..."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Fix the comparison axis; separate social category from legal status, right from institution and scheme from outcome; test the closest homogenisation, causation or stale-data distractor.

Why this earns marks: It prevents a familiar label or aggregate statistic from replacing the exact concept, institutional mandate, mechanism or evidence status.

How to improve this answer: For "Consider the following statements: Statement I: In India, State Governments have no power for...", state why the nearest distractor fails on definition, group variation, causation, constitutional boundary, date or status.

M1. 10 marks | 150 words

Question: Explain the constitutional relationship between Articles 256, 257, 365 and 356. Why is non-compliance with Union directions not equivalent to automatic President's Rule?

Demand decoding: Explain the 256-257-365-356 sequence and expressly rebut automaticity.

Model solution

Article 256 requires States to ensure compliance with parliamentary and applicable laws and permits Union directions for that purpose. Article 257 requires State executive power not to impede Union executive power and permits specified directions concerning national/military communications and railway protection.

Article 365 provides that failure to comply with Union directions may permit the President to hold that State government cannot be carried on according to the Constitution. It therefore supplies a relevant constitutional inference.

It does not automatically impose President's Rule. Article 356 still requires presidential satisfaction based on relevant material, parliamentary approval and temporal limits. *S.R. Bommai* makes the proclamation reviewable and ordinarily protects floor determination of political majority.

Thus, Articles 256-257 enable coordination, Article 365 marks serious non-compliance, and Article 356 supplies the exceptional remedy. Treating the sequence as automatic would convert federal directions into unrestricted Union control.

Why this earns marks: The answer separates coordination, evidentiary consequence and exceptional remedy with *Bommai* control.

How to improve this answer: Cut the opening to one line; use a four-box chain and reserve the final sentence for why automaticity would destroy federal balance.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Explain the constitutional relationship between Articles 256, 257, 365 and 356. Why is non-compliance with Union directions not equivalent to...".

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: The answer separates coordination, evidentiary consequence and exceptional remedy with *Bommai* control. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: Cut the opening to one line; use a four-box chain and reserve the final sentence for why automaticity would destroy federal balance. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Explain the constitutional relationship between Articles 256, 257, 365 and 356. Why is non-compliance with Union directions not equivalent to...".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise three points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

M2. 10 marks | 150 words

Question: Distinguish the Inter-State Council, Zonal Councils, North Eastern Council and NITI Aayog by source, composition logic and function.

Demand decoding: Distinguish four bodies by legal source, composition logic and function.

Model solution

These bodies all facilitate coordination but have different legal foundations.

The **Inter-State Council** is contemplated by Article 263 and was established by presidential order in 1990. Chaired by the Prime Minister, it advises on disputes and common policy; its recommendations are not binding.

The **five Zonal Councils** are statutory bodies under the States Reorganisation Act, 1956. Chaired by the Union Home Minister, they address regional administrative and inter-State issues.

The **North Eastern Council** is a separate statutory institution under the NEC Act, 1971; it is not a sixth Zonal Council.

NITI Aayog was created by executive resolution in 2015. It is a policy and development forum, not a constitutional or statutory body and not a substitute for the Finance Commission.

Thus, "intergovernmental body" does not establish legal status. Article, statute and executive resolution must be separately identified.

Why this earns marks: Each body is classified by Article, statute or executive resolution and the NEC trap is expressly closed.

How to improve this answer: Present a compact four-row table; add that Article 263 enables presidential establishment rather than saying the Constitution itself permanently constituted the ISC.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Distinguish the Inter-State Council, Zonal Councils, North Eastern Council and NITI Aayog by source, composition logic and function."

Analytical body:

- Claim and named evidence:** These bodies all facilitate coordination but have different legal foundations.
Analysis: Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- Claim and named evidence:** The Inter-State Council is contemplated by Article 263 and was established by presidential order in 1990. Chaired by the Prime Minister, it advises on disputes and common policy; its recommendations are not binding. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- Claim and named evidence:** The five Zonal Councils are statutory bodies under the States Reorganisation Act, 1956. Chaired by the Union Home Minister, they address regional administrative and inter-State issues. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- Claim and named evidence:** The North Eastern Council is a separate statutory institution under the NEC Act, 1971; it is not a sixth Zonal Council. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

5. **Claim and named evidence:** NITI Aayog was created by executive resolution in 2015. It is a policy and development forum, not a constitutional or statutory body and not a substitute for the Finance Commission.

Analysis: Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Distinguish the Inter-State Council, Zonal Councils, North Eastern Council and NITI Aayog by source, composition logic and function."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise three points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

M3. 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Examine whether All-India Services strengthen administrative unity at an excessive cost to State autonomy.

Demand decoding: Examine both administrative-unity gains and State-autonomy costs before a balanced judgment.

Model solution

Article 312 permits common services for Union and States after a Rajya Sabha national-interest resolution. IAS, IPS and Indian Forest Service embody India's integrated administrative federalism.

Benefits: Common recruitment and training establish professional standards, enable movement of experience across States and Union, and provide continuity during crises. Officers serving State cadres possess local administrative knowledge while connecting implementation to national law and programmes. Ambedkar's "strategic posts" rationale remains relevant for a diverse federation.

Autonomy costs: Cadre allocation, deputation, disciplinary control and central empanelment can create divided accountability. States may perceive officer shortages or recall/deputation disputes as Union pressure. Uniform career incentives can also weaken responsiveness to local political priorities.

The design is not inherently anti-federal because officers work under State governments in State posts and new services require Rajya Sabha approval. The problem arises when shared control becomes unilateral command.

Reform should use transparent deputation rules, meaningful State consultation, predictable cadre strength, protection against partisan transfer, and joint performance frameworks. Specialised State services should be strengthened rather than displaced.

Thus, All-India Services are a federal bridge, not merely a centralising instrument. Their legitimacy depends on genuinely shared personnel governance.

Why this earns marks: It gives constitutional basis, mechanisms, competing accountability concerns and implementable personnel reforms.

How to improve this answer: Name the Rajya Sabha trigger early and compress benefits to three points so the shared-control reform paragraph remains visible.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Examine whether All-India Services strengthen administrative unity at an excessive cost to State autonomy."

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Article 312 permits common services for Union and States after a Rajya Sabha national-interest resolution. IAS, IPS and Indian Forest Service embody India's integrated administrative federalism. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical

scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

2. **Claim and named evidence:** The design is not inherently anti-federal because officers work under State governments in State posts and new services require Rajya Sabha approval. The problem arises when shared control becomes unilateral command. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Thus, All-India Services are a federal bridge, not merely a centralising instrument. Their legitimacy depends on genuinely shared personnel governance. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It gives constitutional basis, mechanisms, competing accountability concerns and implementable personnel reforms. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: Name the Rajya Sabha trigger early and compress benefits to three points so the shared-control reform paragraph remains visible. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Examine whether All-India Services strengthen administrative unity at an excessive cost to State autonomy."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

M4. 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Cesses, surcharges and centrally sponsored schemes can re-centralise fiscal federalism even when tax devolution remains high. Analyse.

Demand decoding: Analyse how non-divisible levies and conditional schemes alter effective autonomy despite a headline devolution share.

Model solution

The Finance Commission may recommend a substantial State share, but effective fiscal autonomy depends on the base being shared and the conditions attached to other transfers.

Article 270 distributes the divisible pool, while Article 271 permits Union-purpose surcharges whose proceeds are not shareable. Cesses are similarly commonly kept outside the divisible pool. Growth in these instruments can reduce the proportion of gross Union tax revenue subject to the stated devolution percentage.

Centrally sponsored schemes support national priorities and equal citizenship, but detailed guidelines, matching contributions and fragmented funding may constrain State budgeting. States carry major responsibilities in health, agriculture, police and local services, so conditional transfers can convert them into implementation agencies.

Counterarguments matter. Cesses can finance identifiable national externalities; schemes can reduce interstate inequality; and the 16th Finance Commission retains 41% rules-based vertical devolution. State capacity and accountability also justify performance conditions.

The corrective is not abolition but transparency and consent: sunset clauses and reporting for cesses, a protected divisible-pool base, fewer and more flexible schemes, predictable Union shares, outcome-based rather than

input-heavy conditions, and regular ISC/GST consultation.

Thus, formal devolution and practical autonomy can diverge. Fiscal federalism must be evaluated through total transfer design, not the headline percentage alone.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes Article 270 from Article 271 and tests both justification and federal cost before calibrated reforms.

How to improve this answer: Avoid unsupported quantitative claims; add a one-line distinction between the divisible pool and gross Union tax revenue.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Cesses, surcharges and centrally sponsored schemes can re-centralise fiscal federalism even when tax devolution remains high. Analyse."

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The Finance Commission may recommend a substantial State share, but effective fiscal autonomy depends on the base being shared and the conditions attached to other transfers. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Thus, formal devolution and practical autonomy can diverge. Fiscal federalism must be evaluated through total transfer design, not the headline percentage alone. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It distinguishes Article 270 from Article 271 and tests both justification and federal cost before calibrated reforms. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: Avoid unsupported quantitative claims; add a one-line distinction between the divisible pool and gross Union tax revenue. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Cesses, surcharges and centrally sponsored schemes can re-centralise fiscal federalism even when tax devolution remains high. Analyse."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise five points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

M5. 20 marks | 250-300 words

Question: Critically evaluate the constitutional and institutional framework for inter-State river-water disputes in India.

Demand decoding: Critically evaluate constitutional design, statutory process, implementation weaknesses and reform.

Model solution

River basins ignore political boundaries, making water disputes a test of federal adjudication, scientific capacity and political compliance.

Article 262 authorises Parliament to provide adjudication and exclude court jurisdiction. The Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956 creates dispute-specific tribunals, while the River Boards Act, 1956 envisages cooperative basin management.

Strengths: Tribunals provide specialised fact-finding; awards are final and binding under statute; jurisdiction exclusion can prevent parallel litigation; Union facilitation offers a national forum.

Weaknesses: Delays occur in negotiation, tribunal creation, evidence and decision. States dispute flow data, project effects and distress-year sharing. Publication and implementation may generate new litigation. Ad-hoc tribunals lose institutional memory, and climate change makes historical averages less reliable.

The 2019 Amendment Bill proposed a dispute-resolution committee and permanent tribunal with benches, but it lapsed with the Seventeenth Lok Sabha. A later revised proposal is also not current law.

Reform requires a permanent professional secretariat even if benches remain dispute-specific, independent basin data, time-bound stages, ecological-flow and climate scenarios, transparent distress-sharing formulas, compliance monitoring and stronger river-basin organisations. Courts should retain narrow constitutional review while respecting Article 262's jurisdiction design.

Thus, adjudication is necessary but insufficient. Durable settlement requires continuous cooperative basin governance before and after an award.

Why this earns marks: It covers Article 262, both 1956 laws, strengths, delay/data/climate limits and correctly bounded Bill status.

How to improve this answer: Write the process as negotiation -> tribunal -> publication -> implementation; mention the Bill lapsed, not merely that it was unpassed.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Critically evaluate the constitutional and institutional framework for inter-State river-water disputes in India."

Analytical body:

- Claim and named evidence:** River basins ignore political boundaries, making water disputes a test of federal adjudication, scientific capacity and political compliance. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- Claim and named evidence:** Strengths: Tribunals provide specialised fact-finding; awards are final and binding under statute; jurisdiction exclusion can prevent parallel litigation; Union facilitation offers a national forum. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- Claim and named evidence:** The 2019 Amendment Bill proposed a dispute-resolution committee and permanent tribunal with benches, but it lapsed with the Seventeenth Lok Sabha. A later revised proposal is also not current law. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- Claim and named evidence:** Thus, adjudication is necessary but insufficient. Durable settlement requires continuous cooperative basin governance before and after an award. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It covers Article 262, both 1956 laws, strengths, delay/data/climate limits and correctly bounded Bill status. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "Critically evaluate the constitutional and institutional framework for inter-State river-water disputes in India."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise six to eight points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

M6. 20 marks | 250-300 words

Question: The constitutional freedom of trade under Part XIII is a federal common-market guarantee, not a promise of tax-free commerce. Discuss with case law.

Demand decoding: Discuss Part XIII as a common-market guarantee using the current nine-judge doctrine.

Model solution

Articles 301-307 seek an integrated economic union while preserving regulatory and fiscal space.

Article 301 declares trade, commerce and intercourse throughout India free. Article 302 permits Parliament to impose public-interest restrictions. Article 303 generally bars preference or discrimination between States, with a parliamentary scarcity exception. States may levy non-discriminatory taxes under Article 304(a) and impose reasonable public-interest restrictions under Article 304(b) with previous presidential sanction.

Early cases complicated the framework. *Atiabari Tea* focused on measures directly and immediately restricting trade. *Automobile Transport* developed a compensatory-tax doctrine, allowing levies linked to trading facilities.

In *Jindal Stainless* (2016), a nine-judge bench rejected compensatory tax as lacking constitutional text. Article 301 does not create freedom from taxation. The central question for a State tax is hostile or protectionist discrimination under Article 304(a). Clauses (a) and (b) are distinct; a discriminatory tax cannot be saved merely as a reasonable restriction.

GST later supplied a constitutional fiscal mechanism for a common market through Articles 246A, 269A and 279A, though State participation and Council bargaining remain federal features.

Therefore, Part XIII balances integration with autonomy. It prohibits economic protectionism, not every tax or regulation. The modern test is non-discrimination, constitutional competence and procedural compliance.

Why this earns marks: It maps Articles 301-304, traces doctrine and correctly centres *Jindal Stainless* on discrimination rather than tax immunity.

How to improve this answer: Prioritise *Jindal Stainless*; compress the two older cases and explicitly separate Article 304(a) taxation from 304(b) restrictions.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "The constitutional freedom of trade under Part XIII is a federal common-market guarantee, not a promise of tax-free commerce. Discuss with case law."

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** Articles 301-307 seek an integrated economic union while preserving regulatory and fiscal space. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** GST later supplied a constitutional fiscal mechanism for a common market through Articles 246A, 269A and 279A, though State participation and Council bargaining remain federal features. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** Therefore, Part XIII balances integration with autonomy. It prohibits economic protectionism, not every tax or regulation. The modern test is non-discrimination, constitutional competence and procedural compliance. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It maps Articles 301-304, traces doctrine and correctly centres Jindal Stainless on discrimination rather than tax immunity. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: Prioritise Jindal Stainless; compress the two older cases and explicitly separate Article 304(a) taxation from 304(b) restrictions. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in "The constitutional freedom of trade under Part XIII is a federal common-market guarantee, not a promise of tax-free commerce. Discuss with case law."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise six to eight points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

M7. 20 marks | 250-300 words

Question: "The principal weakness of Centre-State relations is institutional under-use rather than constitutional scarcity." Evaluate and suggest reforms.

Demand decoding: Evaluate whether under-use or constitutional design better explains conflict, then suggest matched reforms.

Model solution

The Constitution supplies extensive mechanisms: divided legislative fields, Rajya Sabha safeguards, Inter-State Council, Finance Commission, GST Council, Article 131 adjudication, water tribunals, mutual delegation and commission-developed conventions. Yet conflict persists because these mechanisms are irregularly or asymmetrically used.

The full Inter-State Council meets infrequently, while major Concurrent legislation may proceed without structured State consultation. Governor assent and government-formation disputes turn convention into litigation. Cesses and scheme conditions weaken the practical effect of devolution. Water tribunals suffer delay and implementation gaps. CBI general-consent withdrawals reveal distrust in central agencies.

However, constitutional design also contributes. Residuary power, Article 253, Article 356, Governor appointment, Article 293 borrowing consent and vertical fiscal imbalance give the Union superior leverage. Institutional activation alone cannot erase this structural tilt.

Reform should therefore combine use and redesign: regular ISC meetings with tracked responses; mandatory consultation protocols for Concurrent laws; neutral Governor conventions and reasoned decisions; transparent cesses and flexible schemes; a GST dispute mechanism; shared river data and implementation bodies; comprehensive CBI legislation; and joint All-India Service governance.

Sarkaria and Punchhi already provide much of this menu. *S.R. Bommai* and *Mohit Minerals* show that courts can protect boundaries but cannot substitute for political dialogue.

The proposition is substantially correct: India has enough forums, but insufficient habits of consultation. Trust requires repeated, rule-bound use of institutions while correcting the Union's strongest structural asymmetries.

Why this earns marks: It supplies both institutional and structural causes, named forums/cases and a reform package tied to each diagnosed weakness.

How to improve this answer: Use two body subheads-Under-use and Structural tilt-then pair each reform with ISC, GST, water, CBI or fiscal architecture.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in ""The principal weakness of Centre-State relations is institutional under-use rather than constitutional scarcity." Evaluate and suggest reforms.".

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Sarkaria and Punchhi already provide much of this menu. S.R. Bommai and Mohit Minerals show that courts can protect boundaries but cannot substitute for political dialogue. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Why this earns marks: It supplies both institutional and structural causes, named forums/cases and a reform package tied to each diagnosed weakness. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** How to improve this answer: Use two body subheads-Under-use and Structural tilt-then pair each reform with ISC, GST, water, CBI or fiscal architecture. **Analysis:** Connect structure or institution -> norm/incentive/power/agency mechanism -> differentiated social outcome -> feedback or policy implication. **Qualification:** State internal group variation, regional/historical scope, correlation-versus-causation or legal-norm-versus-lived-outcome boundary.

Counter-position / limit: Neither a constitutional provision, one scheme, aggregate correlation nor a single community example establishes uniform implementation, causation or national experience; test institutions, power, agency, intersectionality, region, period and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the sociological demand in ""The principal weakness of Centre-State relations is institutional under-use rather than constitutional scarcity." Evaluate and suggest reforms.".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, spend about one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing the mechanism; define and state a thesis; organise six to eight points as claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; compress examples before mechanisms and reserve the final minute for causation, group variation and legal-outcome limits.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

19. Representation as a fourth Centre-State dimension - optional

- State influence at the Union depends not only on Lists and transfers but on seats in Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha and the Presidential Electoral College.
- The 42nd, 84th and 87th Amendment sequence separated inter-State seat allocation freeze from permissible intra-State boundary readjustment.
- [CURRENT] The 2026 delimitation package was defeated; its proposed 850-seat figure is not law.
- [ANALYSIS] Representation and devolution are two currencies of the same grievance where population growth affects both political and fiscal weight.
- [LIMIT] Full representational-federalism treatment belongs to Polity 12 and Parliament; no seat projection or implementation date should be invented.

20. Executive federalism and institutional under-use - optional

- Much Indian federal coordination occurs among Prime Minister, Chief Ministers, ministers and officials rather than through legislatures.
- Executive federalism can respond quickly but may weaken transparency and opposition participation.
- Zonal mechanisms often solve operational questions; the ISC should address national structural disputes.
- A stronger ISC secretariat, regular agenda cycle and response-to-recommendation duty would turn consultation into accountable process.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Four dimensions

- Legislative: Articles 245-255.
- Administrative: Articles 256-263.
- Financial: Articles 265-293.
- Inter-State/economic: Articles 261-263 and 301-307.
- Relations interact: legal competence, implementation and finance must be analysed together.

Legislative recall

- Standard List counts: 100 / 61 / 52.
- Article 245: territorial reach; Parliament not invalid merely for extra-territorial operation.
- Article 246: Union > Concurrent > State in constitutional priority.
- Article 248 + Union Entry 97: residuary power with Parliament.
- 42nd Amendment moved five State subjects to Concurrent: education, forests, weights/measures, wildlife, administration of justice.
- Parliament in State field: 249, 250, 252, 253, 356.
- R-N-S-I-P mnemonic.

Doctrine order

1. Identify pith and substance.
 2. Locate competence.
 3. Test whether encroachment is incidental/ancillary.
 4. Harmoniously construe overlap.
 5. Apply Article 254 only for Concurrent-field repugnancy.
 6. Use federal supremacy only for irreconcilable conflict.
- Colourable legislation prevents indirect evasion.
 - Territorial nexus concerns reach, not subject classification.
 - Presidential assent cannot cure absence of State competence; Parliament may later override the assented State law.

State-law control

- Prior presidential sanction and reservation are different.
- Article 200: Governor options; compulsory reservation for High Court-endangering Bill.
- Article 201: President assent/withhold; may return non-Money Bill.
- Current assent doctrine: no fixed judicial deadlines, no deemed assent, prolonged inaction reviewable through direction to act.

Administrative relations

- Article 256: State compliance with parliamentary/applicable law; Union directions.
- Article 257: State must not impede Union; communications and railway directions.
- Article 339(2): ST welfare directions.

- Article 350A: primary mother-tongue facilities.
- Article 365 is an inference route, not automatic President's Rule.
- Article 356 remains controlled by Parliament and Bommai review.
- Articles 258/258A: mutual delegation.

Services and agencies

- AIS: IAS, IPS, Indian Forest Service; Article 312 Rajya Sabha trigger.
- Indian Foreign Service is not AIS.
- CBI: Section 6 DSPE State consent; constitutional courts can order probe.
- West Bengal 2024 decided maintainability at preliminary stage, not all merits.

Financial map

Article	Recall
265	No tax except authority of law
268	Union levy, State collection/appropriation
269	Union collection, assignment to States
269A	Inter-State GST apportionment
270	Divisible-pool sharing
271	Union surcharge, not shared
275	Constitutional grants
282	Any-public-purpose discretionary grants
280	Finance Commission
292/293	Union/State borrowing

- Article 276 profession-tax cap: Rs 2,500 annually.
- Concurrent List has no general tax entry; GST uses Article 246A.
- State borrowing only within India; Union consent if Union loan remains outstanding.

Emergency-linked relations

- Article 355 is a Union duty, not a free-standing takeover power.
- Article 356 is exceptional, parliament-controlled and judicially reviewable.
- Article 357 governs temporary exercise/delegation of State legislative power.
- Article 360 is a separate financial-emergency route and has never been proclaimed.
- Article 365 may supply relevant material; it does not automatically impose President's Rule.

Fiscal evolution and 16th FC

- Plan era: Planning Commission/NDC + Article 282 discretion.
- NITI Aayog replaced Planning Commission in 2015; no devolution power.
- 14th FC: 42%; 15th and 16th: 41%.
- 16th FC weights: income distance 42.5; population 17.5; demographic 10; area 10; forest/ecology 10; GDP contribution 10.
- Tax effort removed; contribution to GDP added.
- Revenue-deficit, sector and State-specific grants discontinued in accepted framework.
- Cesses/surcharges outside divisible pool remain grievance.

GST

- Articles 246A, 269A, 279A; 101st Amendment.

- Union vote one-third, States two-thirds; three-fourths weighted decision threshold.
- Mohit Minerals: recommendations not binding.
- Consensus still matters for harmonisation.

Inter-State relations

- Article 262 water disputes; Parliament can exclude courts.
- Existing system: dispute-specific tribunals.
- 2019 permanent-tribunal Bill passed Lok Sabha, later lapsed; a revised proposal is also not law.
- Article 263 ISC; established 1990 by presidential order; advisory.
- Five Zonal Councils statutory under SRA 1956.
- NEC separate 1971 Act.
- NITI and National Security Council executive/non-statutory.
- Article 261: full faith and credit; civil judgments executable India-wide.

Part XIII common market

- Article 301 freedom.
- 302 Parliament public-interest restrictions.
- 303 no State preference; Parliament scarcity exception.
- 304(a) non-discriminatory State tax.
- 304(b) reasonable restriction + previous presidential sanction.
- Jindal Stainless 2016 rejected compensatory-tax doctrine.
- Article 301 is not tax-free commerce.

Minor minerals

- MMDR Act 1957.
- Centre notifies minor minerals under Section 3(e).
- States make concession rules under Section 15.

Commission reform menu

- Rajamannar: maximal State autonomy.
- Sarkaria: Article 356 last resort, neutral Governors, ISC, Concurrent consultation.
- Punchhi: modern Governor rules, stronger ISC, localised-emergency proposal.

PYQ routes

- 2019: harmonious construction first; federal supremacy last.
- 2020: emergency/disaster/farm legislation -> competence + consultation.
- 2021: CBI consent is real but not absolute against constitutional courts.
- 2022: party incentives vary with national reach, regional mandate and whether a party holds Union or State office.
- 2023 Article 356: *Bommai* review plus coalition and regional-party politics reduced misuse.
- 2023 GST: Articles 246A/269A/279A institutionalise accommodation, qualified by State fiscal-space concerns.
- 2024 Mains: diagnose recent change + specific trust reforms.
- 2024 Prelims: inter-State trade/migration/quarantine are Union fields.
- 2025 Mains: plan discretion -> FC/GST/NITI rules, with continuing imbalance.
- 2025 Prelims: ISC constitutional provision; NSC executive; Zonal Councils statutory.
- 2025 Prelims: Centre notifies minor category; States regulate concessions.

Final trap checklist

- Use 100/61/52, not stale 98/59/52.
- Article 249 does not require Emergency.
- Article 252 law cannot be unilaterally amended by a State.

- Article 254 is mainly Concurrent repugnancy.
- Article 365 does not automatically impose President's Rule.
- Indian Foreign Service is not All-India Service.
- GST is not a Concurrent List entry.
- Article 271 surcharge is outside divisible pool.
- NITI does not replace Finance Commission.
- Permanent river-water tribunal is not current law.
- ISC advisory; Zonal Councils statutory; NSC executive.
- Article 301 does not prohibit all taxation.
- Jindal rejected compensatory-tax doctrine.
- State rule-making over minor-mineral concessions exists.
- No fixed Governor-assent timeline or deemed assent under current doctrine.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/12: Four-dimensional constitutional map

CENTRE-STATE AND INTER-STATE RELATIONS

- LEGISLATIVE: Articles 245-255 and Seventh Schedule
- ADMINISTRATIVE: Articles 256-263
- FINANCIAL: Articles 265-293 plus 246A / 269A / 279A
- INTER-STATE / MARKET: Articles 261-263 and 301-307

METHOD: identify field -> constitutional route -> check -> remedy.

MUST REMEMBER: Keep four owned dimensions separate: legislative relations under Articles 245-255, administrative relations under Articles 256-263 and 355/365, financial relations under Articles 268-293, and inter-State coordination under Articles 261-263 and 301-307.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/12: Legislative competence and State-field entry

COMPETENCE FIRST

Article 245 reach -> Article 246 lists -> Article 248 residue

- Union 100 | State 61 | Concurrent 52
- Article 246A: special GST competence

PARLIAMENT IN STATE FIELD

249 Rajya Sabha | 250 Emergency | 252 State request | 253 treaty | 356 breakdown

Each route has a separate trigger, duration and amendment consequence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/12: Doctrines, repugnancy and State Bills

TRUE NATURE -> ENTRY -> RECONCILIATION -> CONFLICT

pith and substance -> harmonious construction -> Article 254 repugnancy

M. Karunanidhi (1979): real, direct and irreconcilable Concurrent-field conflict

STATE BILL CONTROLS

prior presidential sanction != Governor reservation under Article 200

Article 201 presidential consideration; no automatic assent after State reconsideration.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/12: Administrative cooperation and central agencies

ARTICLES 256-257

State compliance + no impediment -> bounded Union directions

ARTICLES 258 / 258A -> reciprocal entrustment

ARTICLE 312 -> Rajya Sabha route for IAS / IPS / Indian Forest Service

CBI / DSPE ACT

State consent for ordinary operation; Articles 32/226 court orders remain possible

2024 West Bengal ruling: Article 131 suit maintainable at preliminary stage, merits open.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/12: Articles 355-365 and judicial limits

DUTY -> REMEDY -> TEMPORARY CONSEQUENCE

Article 355 Union duty

Article 356 exceptional proclamation + Parliament + review

Article 357 temporary exercise of State legislative power

Article 360 separate financial-emergency route

Article 365 non-compliance may supply material, never automatic rule

State of Rajasthan (1977) -> review not wholly excluded

S.R. Bommai (1994) -> federalism, review and floor-test discipline.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/12: Fiscal architecture from tax to borrowing

ARTICLE 265: authority of law

268 / 269 / 269A -> assigned and apportioned revenue

270 -> divisible pool | 271 -> Union surcharge outside sharing

275 -> constitutional grants | 282 -> any-public-purpose grants

280 -> Finance Commission | 292 / 293 -> borrowing

285 / 289 -> reciprocal property and income tax immunities with exceptions.

CLOSE DISTINCTION: Article 254 repugnancy is principally a Concurrent-List conflict rule; pith and substance tests competence, Article 262 permits statutory exclusion for defined river disputes, and Article 263 creates an enabling power rather than a self-executing adjudicatory council.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/12: Fiscal evolution, Sixteenth Finance Commission and GST

PLAN ERA -> FC / GST / NITI ERA

Planning Commission discretion -> NITI has no devolution power

Sixteenth Finance Commission 2026-31 -> 41% vertical share

horizontal weights include income distance, demography, ecology and GDP contribution

GST: Articles 246A + 269A + 279A

Union one-third votes | States two-thirds | three-fourths decision threshold

Mohit Minerals (2022): Council recommendations are recommendatory, not binding.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/12: River-water dispute route and jurisdiction

ARTICLE 262 + 1956 ACT

negotiation -> dispute-specific tribunal -> publication -> implementation
Parliament may exclude court jurisdiction over the defined water dispute
Article 131 does not displace the special Article 262 statutory bar

CURRENT CONTROL

2019 Amendment Bill lapsed with the Seventeenth Lok Sabha
A revised permanent-tribunal proposal is not enacted law
Cauvery implementation uses the 2018 Scheme and management institutions.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/12: Intergovernmental forums and current operation

ARTICLE 263 INTER-STATE COUNCIL

President establishes when public interest requires; inquiry, discussion, recommendation
1990 presidential order | PM chair | advisory

ZONAL COUNCILS

Five statutory councils under States Reorganisation Act 1956 | Home Minister chair
NEC is separate under 1971 Act, not a sixth Zonal Council
2026 official activity: Central, Northern, Eastern and Southern zonal mechanisms.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/12: Common market, recognition and layered regulation

ARTICLE 261 -> recognition of public acts, records and proceedings; civil execution
ARTICLES 301-304 -> free trade with bounded regulation and non-discrimination
Jindal Stainless (2016): no tax-free promise; Article 304(a) targets discrimination

MINOR MINERALS

MMDR Section 3(e) Centre notifies category
Section 15 States make concession rules -> layered power, not State exclusion.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/12: Commissions, eleven PYQs and Prelims firewalls

REFORM EVIDENCE

Rajamannar -> State autonomy | Sarkaria -> cooperative safeguards | Punchhi -> modern machinery

ELEVEN PYQ ROUTES

2019 doctrines | 2020 centralisation | 2021 CBI | 2022 parties/autonomy
2023 Article 356 + GST | 2024 relations reform + list trap
2025 fiscal federalism + constitutional-body + minor-mineral traps

FIREWALLS: Article 365 is not automatic; GST is not a Concurrent-list tax entry;
Zonal Councils are statutory; the 2019 water Bill is not law.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/12: Marks-scaled answer spine and qualified verdict

10 MARKS: definition -> 2-3 anchors -> qualification -> verdict
15 MARKS: thesis -> dimensions -> evidence/case -> counterpoint -> reform
20 MARKS: legislative + administrative + fiscal + inter-State -> diagnosis -> reform

EVIDENCE CHAIN

claim -> Article/institution -> operation -> State/Union counterpoint -> commission remedy

VERDICT

Strong Union power is constitutionally bounded; durable relations require consultation
before compulsion, predictable finance, shared data and reviewable discretion.
LEGAL/SOURCE LIMIT: Special Reference No. 1 of 2025 rejects rigid judicial timelines and
deemed assent, recognises Article 200 discretion, and permits only a limited mandamus
against prolonged, unexplained and indefinite inaction. Do not continue the displaced April
2025 timeline rule.